

The Tao that can be understood cannot be the primal, or cosmic, Tao, just as an idea that can be expressed in words cannot be the infinite idea.

And yet this ineffable Tao was the source of all spirit and matter, and being expressed was the mother of all created things.

Therefore not to desire the things of sense is to know the freedom of spirituality; and to desire is to learn the limitation of matter.

The Tao that is the subject of discussion is not the true Tao.

The quality which can be named is not its true attribute.

That which was before Heaven and Earth is called the Non-Existent.

The Existent is the mother of all things.

Therefore doth the

Existence is beyond the power of words

To define:

Terms may be used

But are none of them absolute.

In the beginning of heaven and earth there were no words,

Words came out of the womb of matter;

And whether a man dispassionately

The Tao that can be expressed in words is not the eternal Tao.

The name that can be defined in words is not the name that never changes.

Non-existence is what we will call the source of heaven and earth.

Existence is the mother of all things.

From eternal non-existence, therefore, we observe the beginning of the existence of the many hidden qualities of

The Tao that can be named is not the eternal Tao.

The Name that can be spoken is not the eternal name.

The Nameless is the beginning of Heaven and Earth.

The Named is the mother of all creatures.

These two things spirit and matter, so different in nature, have the same origin. This unity of origin is the mystery of mysteries, but it is the gateway to spirituality.

wise man seek after the first mystery of the Non-Existent, while seeing in that which exists the Ultimates thereof.

The Non-Existent and Existent are identical in all but name.

This identity of apparent opposites I call the profound, the great deep, the open door of bewilderment.

Sees to the core of life

Or passionately

Sees the surface,

The core and the surface

Are essentially the same,

Words making them seem different

Only to express appearance.

If name be needed, wonder names them both:

From wonder into wonder

Existence opens.

the universe.

From eternal existence, therefore, we clearly observe the overt qualities of the universe.

These two, the hidden and the overt, are originally the same at source, and become different when they manifest themselves.

This same origin is "the smallest of the small."

The absolute "smallest of the small" is the gate from which the beginning of all the parts of the universe emerges.

Observe the mysteries of the Tao without longing.

Survey its appearance with desire.

Both mysteries and appearance come from the same origin but wear a different name;

they are enigmatic.

The greatest mystery is the gate to all mysteries.

When every one recognizes beauty to be only a masquerade, then it is simply ugliness. In the same way goodness, if it is not sincere, is not goodness. So existence and non-existence are incompatible. The difficult and easy are mutually opposites.

When the world speaks of beauty as being beautiful, ugliness is at once defined.
When goodness is seen to be good, evil is at once apparent.
So do existence and non-existence mutually give rise to one another, as that which is difficult and that which is easy, distant and near, high and low, shrill and bass, preceding and

People through finding something beautiful
Think something else unbeautiful,
Through finding one man fit
Judge another unfit.
Life and death, though stemming from each other, seem to conflict as stages of change,
Difficult and easy as phases of achievement,
Long and short as measures of contrast,
High and low as degrees of relation;

When the world understands that beauty is beautiful, ugliness will exist.
When the world understands that goodness is good, evil will exist.
From that we learn that:
Existence affirms non-existence,
Ease affirms difficulty,
Short derives from long, because that is what it is compared to,
Low derives from high, because according to that it is measured,
Echo affirms sound,
After follows before.
Accordingly,
The sage operates without action,

The whole world can see the beautiful as the beautiful only because of the ugly.
The whole world can recognize the good as the good only because of the bad.
Something and nothing create each other.
The difficult and the easy complement each other.
The long and the short define each other.
The high and the low counterbalance

Just as the long and the short, the high and the low, the loud and soft, the before and the behind, are all opposites and each reveals the other.
Therefore the wise man is not conspicuous in his affairs or given to much talking. Though troubles arise he is not irritated. He produces but does not own; he acts but claims no merit; he builds but does not dwell therein; and because he does not dwell therein he never departs.

following.
The Sage therefore is occupied only with that which is without prejudice.
He teaches without verbosity; he acts without effort; he produces with possessing, he acts without regard to the fruit of action; he brings his work to perfection without assuming credit; and claiming nothing as his own, he cannot at any time be said to lose.

tones gives music to a voice
And what is the was of what shall be,
The sanest man
Sets up no deed,
Lays down no law,
Takes everything that happens as it comes,
As something to animate, not to appropriate,
To earn, not to own,
To accept naturally without self-importance:
If you never assume importance
You never lose it.

teaches his pupils without words.
Everything in the universe, when defined, is relative to everything else.
The sage does not try to differentiate things, he does not try to show his preference for things either in deed or in speech.
This does not mean that the sage does nothing or says nothing;
rather, it means that he "accepts things as they are," easily and naturally, without making any demands.

each other.
Before and after follow each other.
Therefore the sage acts without action, teaches without words.
The myriad creatures keep on going without an end, creating life without possessing it, performing deeds without expectations, fulfilling the mission without claiming a victory,
because the sage does not ask for praise,

Neglecting to praise the worthy deters people from emulating them; just as not prizing rare treasures deters a man from becoming a thief; or ignoring the things which awaken desire keeps the heart at rest.

Therefore the wise ruler does not suggest unnecessary things, but seeks to satisfy the minds of his people.

Avoiding distinctions of merit among the people prevents jealousy.

Not setting a value on rare things prevents theft.

Not seeking the things of peace keeps the mind in peace.

Thus the Sage governs by ridding the heart of its desires; giving the stomach due

It is better not to make merit a matter of reward

Lest people conspire and contend,

Not to pile up rich belongings

Lest they rob,

Not to excite by display

Lest they covet.

A sound leader's aim
Is to open

If the exalted are not praised, the humble will not put on airs.

When rare things are not assigned a value, the thief has no reason to steal them.

When the desired object is not shown, the heart has no reason to covet it.

Therefore the sage says:

By emptying their hearts

By filling their stomachs

By weakening their ambition

By strengthening their bones,

Not to value one's own virtues is the way to restrain people from striving for wealth.

Not to value the precious is the way to restrain people from theft.

Not to see the desirable is the way to restrain confusion in the mind.

Therefore the wise way to rule is:

not to give importance to

He seeks to allay appetites but strengthen bones. He ever tries by keeping people in ignorance to keep them satisfied and those who have knowledge he restrains from evil. If he, himself, practices restraint then everything is in quietness.

satisfaction, by resting the muscles and strengthening the bones, by preserving the world from a knowledge of evil and hence from its desire, and by making those who have such knowledge afraid to use it.

He acts by non-action, and by this he governs all.

people's hearts,
Fill their stomachs,
Calm their wills,
Brace their bones
And so to clarify their thoughts and cleanse their needs

That no cunning meddler could touch them:

Without being forced, without strain or constraint,

Good government comes of itself.

prevents the knowledgeable ones from acting according to their knowledge.

He governs by non-action,

And therefore, there is nothing that cannot be done.

Non-quiet and non-order in the world are caused by ambition to attain the unattainable,

and by plotting to go from the undesired to the desired.

If people would obey the laws of the world the way the sage does, there would always be balance between body and soul, and peace and serenity would abound in the world.

oneself,
or try to enrich one's spirit and virtue;
not to be inordinately proud of one's ability,

or try to make unceasing efforts to improve oneself.

Let the people stay free from desire and knowledge in order to avoid the pitfalls that knowledge may bring.

Rule by doing nothing, then everything will be as it should.

The Tao appears to be emptiness but it is never exhausted. Oh, it is profound! It appears to have preceded everything.

Tao is without limitation; its depth is the source of whatsoever is.

It makes shard things round, it brings order out of chaos,

Existence, by nothing bred,

Breeds everything.

Parent of the universe,

It smooths rough edges,

Unties hard knots,

Tempers the sharp

The Tao, if you examine it, will always be empty and will never be full.

In its infinite emptiness lies the source of all

The Tao is based on harmony between emptiness and abundance.

It is the deep source of the myriad creatures.

It softens their sharpness.

It releases their confusion.

It lessens their lustre.

It dulls its own sharpness, unravels its own fetters, softens its own brightness, identifies itself with its own dust.

Oh, it is tranquil! It appears infinite; I do not know from what it proceeds. It even appears to be antecedent to the Lord.

it obscures the brilliant, it is wholly without attachment.

I do not know who gave it birth; it is more ancient than God.

sun,

Lays blowing dust,

Its image in the wellspring never fails.

But how was it conceived?--this image

Of no other sire.

things,

It will remain in its depths forever.

I don't know whose seed it is,

But it looks like the predecessor of the universe itself.

It merges with their dust.

The Tao is so clear and so transparent that it is nearly invisible, nearly formless;

no one can know its origin,

for it came before all creation.

Heaven and earth are not like humans, they are impartial. They regard all things as insignificant, as though they were playthings made of straw. The wise man is also impartial. To him all men are alike and unimportant.

Neither Heaven nor Earth has any predilections; they regard all persons and things as sacrificial images.

The wise man knows no distinctions; he beholds all men as things made for holy uses.

The celestial space is like unto bellows

Nature, immune as to a sacrifice of straw dogs,

Faces the decay of its fruits.

A sound man, immune as to a sacrifice of straw dogs,

Faces the passing of human generations.

The

Heaven and earth do not own all things,

For them, things are like straw dogs.

The sage does not own his words,

For him, all people are like straw dogs.

The hollow space that lies between heaven and earth is like

Heaven and Earth treat all creatures as they treat a straw dog:

with great kindness.

The sage treats the people as he treats a straw dog:

with great kindness.

Between Heaven and Earth there is a big void;

it is like

The space between heaven and earth is like a bellows, it is empty but does not collapse; it moves and more and more issues. A gossip is soon empty, it is doubtful if he can be impartial.

though containing nothing that is solid, it does not at any time collapse; and the more it is set in motion, the more does it produce.

The inflated man, however, is soon exhausted.

Than self-restraint there is nothing better.

universe, like a bellows,

Is always emptying, always full:

The more it yields, the more it holds.

Men came to their wit's end arguing about it

And had better meet it at the marrow.

the blacksmith's bellows.

Hollow in appearance, nothing is lacking,

And if it moves, a lot of what is in it moves.

The person who speaks a lot will be exhausted.

It would be better for him to keep his words to himself.

a bag without a seam, it is like the hole in a bamboo flute.

This void cannot be overpowered:

the more it moves, the more it yields.

Many words lead to less understanding, therefore it is best to guard the void.

The Spirit of the perennial spring is said to be immortal, she is called the Mysterious One.

Like the river in the valley, the spirit is never dried up.

I call it the Mother-Deep.

The motion of

The breath of life moves through a deathless valley

Of mysterious motherhood

Which conceives and bears the universal seed,

The seeming of a

"The valley and the wind will never die."

They are the creators of the one who is the mystical mother,

The one whose

The spirit is as deep as a valley and will never fade.

It is the great mysterious mother.

The gateway

The Mysterious One is typical of the source of heaven and earth. It is continually and endlessly issuing and without effort.

the Mother-Deep I regard as the origin of the Heaven and the Earth.

Forever it endures and moves without design.

world never to end,

Breath for men to draw from as they will:

And the more they take of it, the more remains.

hair is the source of heaven and earth.

This source will never end.

Even if it is exploited endlessly, it will never diminish.

of this mysterious creature is the root of Heaven and Earth.

Although it is invisible, it endures; it will never end.

Heaven is eternal, earth is lasting. The reason why heaven and earth are eternal and lasting is because they do not live for themselves; that is the reason they will ever endure.

Therefore the wise man will keep his personality out of sight and because of so doing he will become notable.

Both Heaven and Earth endure a long time.

The cause of their endurance is their indifference to long life.

This is why the subsist.

Thus the wise man, indifferent

The universe is deathless,

Is deathless because, having no finite self, It stays infinite.

A sound man by not advancing himself

Stays the further

Heaven and earth will exist forever.

The reason they exist forever is that they do not live for themselves and they do not live because of themselves.

Therefore they live forever.

In the same way, the sage stays behind everything and finds himself in front of everything, he is not himself and he is preserved forever.

Since he has no self-interest, his

Heaven and Earth are enduring only because they have no ego;

therefore they can live for ever.

The sage

He subordinates his personality and therefore it is preserved.

Is it not because he is disinterested, that his own interests are conserved?

to himself, is the greatest among men, and taking no care for himself, he is nevertheless preserved.

By being the most unselfish he is the most secure of all.

ahead of himself,

By not confining himself to himself

Sustains himself outside himself:

By never being an end in himself

He endlessly becomes himself.

self-interest can realize itself.

Even though it looks like heaven and earth give life to all creatures, they do not live in order to preserve their own existence, and therefore they live forever and never die.

In his rule over the kingdom, the sage does everything for people, ignoring his personal goals, and ultimately earns glory, honor, and everything he wanted for himself.

does not try to be the first, and does not fight for fame.

Only through unselfishness can he achieve fulfilment.

True goodness is like water, in that it benefits everything and harms nothing. Like water it ever seeks the lowest place, the place that all others avoid. It is closely kin to the Tao.

For a dwelling it chooses the quiet meadow; for a heart the circling eddy.

The greatest virtue is like water; it is good to all things.

It attains the most inaccessible places without strife.

Therefore it is like Tao.

It has the virtue of adapting itself to its place.

It is virtuous like the heart by being

Man at his best, like water,

Serves as he goes along:

Like water he seeks his own level,

The common level of life,

Loves living close to the earth,

Living clear down in his heart,

Loves kinship with

The best of the best is like water.

Water is beneficial to everything,

And does not demand anything for itself in return.

Water stays in places where nothing else stays.

Therefore, water is close to Tao.

At home, it is important for this to be a good place to live in.

In feeling, examine the depths of your heart.

In friendship, maintain good relations with others.

In words, have confidence.

In government, abide by good order.

In

The greatest good is like water: it benefits all life without being noticed.

It flows even to the lowliest places where no one chooses to be and so it is very close to the Tao.

It settles only in quiet locations.

Its deepest heart is always

In generosity it is kind; in speech it is sincere; in authority it is order; in affairs it is ability; in movement it is rhythm.

Inasmuch as it is always peaceable it is never rebuked.

deep.

It is virtuous like speech be being faithful.

It is virtuous like government in regulating.

It is virtuous like a servant in its ability.

It is virtuous like action by being in season.

And because it does not strive it has no enemies.

his neighbors,

The pick of words that tell the truth,

The even tenor of a well-run state,

The fair profit of able dealing,

The right timing of useful deeds,

And for blocking no one's way

No one blames him.

trade, taking things easy will be to your benefit.

In movement, use every opportunity.

Since there is no demand for anything, there is no blame, either.

This shows how the sage, the highest level of good, operates selflessly.

He does good for others but demands nothing of them.

He is satisfied with everything.

He does not covet anything that belongs to someone else.

When he serves as an example for us, the world enjoys peace and tranquillity.

clear.

It offers itself with great goodness.

It keeps its rhythm as it keeps its promises.

It governs tributaries as it governs its people.

It adapts to all necessities.

It moves at the right moment.

It never flaunts its goodness and so it never attracts any blame.

Continuing to fill a
pail after it is full the
water will be wasted.
Continuing to grind
an axe after it is
sharp will soon wear
it away.

Who can protect a
public hall crowded
with gold and
jewels?

It is advisable to
refrain from
continual reaching
after wealth.

Continual handling
and sharpening wears
away the most
durable thing.

If the house be full of
jewels,

Keep stretching a
bow

You repent of the
pull,

A 'whetted saw

Goes thin and dull,

Surrounded with
treasure

You

It is better to leave a
thing alone

Than to hold it and
keep it full to the
brim.

If you sharpen the
blade and use it,

It will not remain
sharp for long.

When gold and jade
fill the

To stop in time is
better than to hold a
full bowl with fear of
spilling.

A knife cannot be
kept constantly
sharp, therefore it is
wise not to flaunt the
blade.

Amass a

The pride of wealth
and position brings
about their own
misfortune. To win
true merit, to
preserve just fame,
the personality must
be retiring. This is
the heavenly Tao.

who shall protect it?

Wealth and glory
bring care along with
pride.

To stop when good
work is done and
honour advancing is
the way of Heaven.

lie ill at ease,

Proud beyond
measure

You come to your
knees:

Do enough, without
vieing,

Be living, not dying.

temple,

No one can protect
them.

When wealth and
honor come together
with pride

Self-destruction
quickly joins them.

After the goal has
been achieved and
the objective has
been honorably
accomplished,

The Tao of heaven

Is to retire from
everything.

hoard of gold and
jade and it cannot be
possessed for ever.

Those who vaunt
their position and
worth risk attracting
blame.

To retire when the
goal is reached: this
is the Tao of Heaven.

WHAT IS POSSIBLE

By patience the animal spirits can be disciplined. By self-control one can unify the character. By close attention to the will, compelling gentleness, one can become like a little child. By purifying the subconscious desires one may be without fault. In ruling his country, if the wise magistrate loves his people, he can avoid compulsion.

In measuring out rewards, the wise magistrate will act like a mother bird.

By conserving the natural and spiritual powers it is possible to escape dissolution.

By restraining the passions and letting gentleness have its sway it is possible to continue as a child.

By purging the mind of impurities it is possible to remain untainted.

By governing the people with love it is possible to

Can you hold the door of your tent

Wide to the firmament?

Can you, with the simple stature

Of a child, breathing nature,

Become, notwithstanding, A man?

Can you continue befriending

With no prejudice, no ban?

Can you, mating with heaven,

Serve as the female part?

Can

Can you always keep your soul focused

So that nothing can divert it from the Tao?

Can you regulate your breathing

And be as soft and relaxed as a baby?

Can you purify yourself and eliminate the hidden

So that you are free

Can one hold the soul in the body, hold the mind in the spirit, and keep them as one?

Can one concentrate the energy of life and keep it supple like a newborn child?

Can one study everything and really know everything without making a mistake?

Can one govern the nation with all the right actions and really love the people?

Can one

While sharply penetrating into every corner, he may appear to be unsuspecting. While quickening and feeding his people, he will be producing but without pride of ownership. He will benefit but without claim of reward. He will persuade, but not compel by force. This is teh, the profoundest virtue.

remain unknown.

By continual use of the Gates of Heaven it is possible to preserve them from rust.

By transparency on all sides it is possible to remain unrecognized.

o bring forth and preserve, to produce without possessing, to act without hope of reward, and to expand without waste, this is the supreme virtue.

your learned head take leaven

From the wisdom of your heart?

If you can bear issue and nourish its growing,

If you can guide without claim or strife,

If you can stay in the lead of men without their knowing,

You are at the core of life.

of all blemish and error?

Can you love the people and govern the state by non-action?

Can you open and close the gates of nature

As a woman can?

Can you be enlightened and aware

And penetrate to the depths of everything, without knowledge?

always make a decision with the right mind?

Can one empty the mind and fill it with the brightness of wisdom and learn to step back from this knowledge?

Can one give life and grow life and yet claim no possession?

Can one supervise and benefit others, yet exercise no authority and rely on no pride?

This is what is called the mysterious virtue.

THE VALUE OF
NON-EXISTENCE

Although the wheel has thirty spokes its utility lies in the emptiness of the hub. The jar is made by kneading clay, but its usefulness consists in its capacity.

The thirty spokes of a carriage wheel uniting at the nave are made useful by the hole in the centre, where nothing exists.

Vessels of moulded earth are useful by

Thirty spokes are made one by holes in a hub,

By vacancies joining them for a wheel's use;

The use of clay in moulding pitchers

Comes from

Thirty spokes unite in the middle of the wheel,

And because of the part between them where nothing exists,

We enjoy the use of the carriage wheel.

Clay is formed into bowls and vessels,

And because of the hollow in it where nothing exists,

We use them as vessels.

Doors and windows are cut into the walls of the house,

And since they are empty

Thirty spokes share one hub, yet the spokes and the hub cannot make use of the carriage.

Mix water, mud and earth and they can be shaped into a vessel, yet they cannot make

A room is made by cutting out windows and doors through the walls, but the space the walls contain measures the room's value.

In the same way matter is necessary to form, but the value of reality lies in its immateriality.

(Or thus: a material body is necessary to existence, but the value of a life is measured by its immaterial soul.)

reason of their hollowness.

Doors and windows are useful by being cut out.

A house is useful because of its emptiness.

Existence, therefore, is like unto gain, but Non-Existence to use.

the hollow of its absence;

Doors, windows, in a house,

Are used for their emptiness:

Thus we are helped by what is not

To use what is.

space, we can use them.

Therefore, on the one hand, we have the advantage of what exists,

And, on the other, we utilize the non-existent.

Without that which does not exist, we cannot take advantage of the wheel, the vessel, or the house.

Without wooden spokes, clay, and walls, we cannot take advantage of the space they contain.

use of the vessel itself.

Cut out windows and doors to create a room, yet they cannot make use of the room itself.

Therefore take the useful as the useless, the useless as the useful.

AVOIDING
DESIRE

An excess of light
blinds the human
eye; an excess of
noise ruins the ear;
an excess of
condiments deadens
the taste.

Light will blind a
man, sound will
make him deaf, taste
will ruin his palate,
the chase will make
him wild, and
precious things will
tempt

The five colors can
blind,
The five tones
deafen,
The five tastes cloy.
The race, the hunt,
can drive men mad
And their

The five colors blind
a person's sight.
The five sounds
deafen a person's
hearing.
The five tastes dull a
person's palate.
Races and hunting
trips make a person
wild.
Things that are hard
to attain are

The five colours
blind man's eye.
The five tones deafen
man's ears.
The five flavours dull
man's taste.
Riding and hunting
drive man's mind
mad.
Precious goods alter
man's

The effect of too
much horse racing
and hunting is bad,
and the lure of
hidden treasure
tempts one to do evil.
Therefore the wise
man attends to the
inner significance of
things and does not
concern himself with
outward appearances.
Therefore he ignores
matter and seeks the
spirit.

him.
Therefore soes the
wise man provide for
the soul and not for
the senses.
He ignores the one
and takes the other
with both hands.

booty leave them no
peace.
Therefore a sensible
man
Prefers the inner to
the outer eye:
He has his yes, --he
has his no.

detrimental to a
person's conduct.
For this reason, the
sage
Prepares his food
according to the size
of his stomach and
not according to the
size of his eyes.
He rejects surfeit,
and opts for less.

behaviour.
Therefore the sage
tries to fill the belly
(the virtuous
character) and not the
eyes (the gateway to
the emotions).
And so he discards
one and keeps the
other.

LOATHING SHAME

Favor and disgrace are alike to be feared, just as too great care or anxiety are bad for the body.

Why are favor and disgrace alike to be feared? To be favored is humiliating; to obtain it is as much to be dreaded as to lose it.

Honour and shame are the same as fear.

Fortune and disaster are the same as the person.

What is said of honour and shame is this: shame is abasement, which is feared whether is be absent or present.

So dignity and shame are inseparable from the fear which both occasion.

What is said

Favor and disfavor have been called equal worries,

Success and failure have been called equal ailments.

How can favor and disfavor be called equal worries?

Because winning favor burdens a man

With the fear of losing it.

How can success and failure be called equal ailments?

Because a man thinks of the personal body as self.

"Honor and disgrace are like fear.

Fortune and disaster are like our body."

What does "Honor and disgrace are like fear" mean?

Honor is located in a high place, and disgrace is located in a low place.

When you have them, it is as if you are in a state of fear, and when you no longer have them, it is also as if you are in a state of fear.

Therefore, honor and disgrace

Accept favour and disgrace as a threat that troubles the body like a disease.

What does it mean to accept favour and disgrace as a threat?

Everyone seeks to be favoured.

No one seeks to be disgraced.

When one receives it, it causes alarm.

When one loses it, it causes alarm.

Therefore favour and disgrace are both threatening.

What does it mean that the disease troubles one's body?

To lose favor is to be in disgrace and of course is to be dreaded.

Why are excessive care and great anxiety alike bad for one? The very reason I have anxiety is because I have a body. If I have not body why would I be anxious?

Therefore if he who administers the empire, esteems it as his own body, then he is worthy to be trusted with the empire.

of fortune and disaster is this: fortune and disaster are things which befall the person.

So without personality how should I suffer disaster or the reverse?

Therefore by the accident of good fortune a man may rule the world for a time.

But by virtue of love he may rule the world for ever.

When he no longer thinks of the personal body as self

Neither failure nor success can ail him.

One who knows his lot to be the lot of all other men

Is a safe man to guide them,

One who recognizes all men as members of his own body

Is a sound man to guard them.

are like fear.

What does "Fortune and disaster are like our body" mean?

We have fortune and disaster because we have a body.

When we do not have a body, how can fortune and disaster affect us?

Therefore, the person who relates to the world like he relates to the good fortune of his body can rule the world.

The world can be safely entrusted to the person who loves it like he loves his body.

disease because one treasures one's body.

If one does not love one's body, one will no longer suffer from the disease.

Therefore

entrust the land under Heaven to the one who does not treasure his body,

sanction the land under Heaven to the one who does not love his body.

He who does not love even his own body will not treasure rulership, and so he will truly care for all things.

IN PRAISE OF THE
PROFOUND

It is unseen because
it is colorless; it is
unheard because it is
soundless; when
seeking to grasp it, it
eludes one, because it
is incorporeal.

Because of these
qualities it cannot be
examined, and yet
they form an
essential unity.
Superficially it
appears abstruse, but
in its depths it is not
obscure. It has been
nameless forever! It
appears and then
disappears.

Ie. Plainness is that
which cannot be seen
by looking at it.

He. Stillness is that
which cannot be
heard by listening to
it.

We. Rareness is that
which cannot be felt
by handling it.

These, being
indiscernible, may be
regarded as an unity -
I H W, Tao.

It is not bright above
nor dark beneath.

Infinite in

What we look for
beyond seeing

And call the unseen,

Listen for beyond
hearing

And call the unheard,

Grasp for beyond
reaching

And call the
withheld,

Merge beyond
understanding

In a oneness

Which does not
merely rise and give
light,

Does not merely set
and leave darkness,

But forever sends
forth a succession of
living things as

What we look at and
do not see is called
simplicity.

What we listen to and
do not hear is called
rarity.

What we clasp and do
not catch is called
delicateness.

These three cannot be
discerned,

So they unite to
become one.

When it is revealed, it
does not dazzle,

When it is concealed,
it is not dark,

When it is infinite, it
is not defined.

It attains the
non-existent.

Its name is the

That which cannot be
seen is called
invisible.

That which cannot be
heard is called
inaudible.

That which cannot be
held is called
intangible.

These three cannot
be defined, therefore
they are merged as
one.

Look at its highest
part - it is not bright.

Look at its lowest
part - it is not dark.

It never ends and it
cannot be

It is what is known as
the form of the
formless, the image
of the imageless. It is
called the
transcendental, its
face (or destiny)
cannot be seen in
front, or its back (or
origin) behind.

But by holding fast to
the Tao of the
ancients, the wise
man may understand
the present, because
he knows the origin
of the past. This is
the clue to the Tao.

operation, it is yet
without name.

Issuing forth it enters
into Itself.

This is the
appearance of the
Non-Apparent, the
form of the
Non-Existent.

This is the
unfathomable
mystery.

Going before, its face
is not seen; following
after, its back is not
observed.

Yet to regulate one's
life by the ancient
knowledge of Tao is
to have found the
path.

mysterious

As the unbegotten
existence to which
they return.

That is why men
have called them
empty phenomena,
Meaningless images,

In a mirage

With no face to meet,

No back to follow.

Yet one who is
anciently aware of
existence

Is master of every
moment,

Feels no break since
time beyond time

In the way life flows.

form of the formless

And its image is that
which does not have
an image.

It is mysterious.

Meet it, and you will
not be able to see its
face,

Follow it, and you will
not be able to see its
back.

By adhering to the
ancient Tao,

You will be master of
the essence of the
present

And you will be aware
of the origin of the
past.

That is the clue to the
Tao.

named.

It returns to
nothingness.

Therefore it is called
the shape without
shape and the
substance without
substance.

It is called
indefinable.

One approaches it
but cannot see its
beginning.

One follows it but
cannot see its end.

Hold fast to the
original path in order
to control the realm
of the present.

To know the ancient
origin is the
discipline of Tao.

THAT WHICH
REVEALS TEH

In olden times the ones who were considered worthy to be called masters were subtle, spiritual, profound, wise. Their thoughts could not be easily understood.

Since they were hard to understand I will try to make them clear. They were cautious like men wading a river in winter. They were reluctant like men who feared their neighbors. They were reserved like guests in the presence of their host. They were elusive like ice at the point of melting.

The ancient wise men were skilful in their mysterious acquaintance with profundities.

They were fathomless in their depths; so profound, that I cannot bring them forth to my mind.

They were cautious, like one who crosses a swollen river.

They were reserved, like one who doubts his fellows.

They were watchful, like one who travels abroad.

They were retiring, like snow beneath the sun.

Long ago the land was ruled with a wisdom

Too fine, too deep, to be fully understood

And, since it was beyond men's full understanding,

Only some of it has come down to us, as in these sayings:

'Alert as a winter-farer on an icy stream,'

'Wary as a man in ambush,'

'Considerate as a welcome guest,'

'Selfless as melting ice,'

'Green as an uncut tree,

'Open as a valley,'

And this

Long ago, the man of Tao was learned, incisive,

And so profound that it was difficult to comprehend him.

Since it is impossible to understand him, I will try to sketch his image:

He is cautious, like a person crossing a stream during the winter.

He is hesitant, like a person who fears his neighbors.

He is modest, like a person who is another's guest.

He is unassuming, like ice that slowly melts.

He is simple, like a log that has not been carved.

Since ancient times, he who is versed in the Tao has been regarded as subtle, mysterious and obscurely discerning, too profound to be understood.

And because he is elusive, one is barely able to describe him.

Prudent as if fording a stream in winter.

Wary as if in fear of those around him.

Formal as if holding a memorial ceremony.

He lets his heart yield like melting ice.

They were like unseasoned wood. They were like a valley between high mountains. They were obscure like troubled waters. (They were cautious because they were conscious of the deeper meanings of life and its possibilities.)

We can clarify troubled waters by slowly quieting them. We can bring the unconscious to life by slowly moving them. But he who has the secret of the Tao does not desire for more. Being content, he is able to mature without desire to be newly fashioned.

were simple, like newly felled timber.

They were lowly, like the valley.

They were obscure, like muddy water.

May not a man take muddy water and make it clear by keeping still?

May not a man take a dead thing and make it alive by continuous motion?

Those who follow this Tao have no need of replenishing, and being devoid of all properties, they grow old without need of being filled.

one also, 'Roiled as a torrent,

Why roiled as a torrent?

Because when a man is in turmoil how shall he find peace

Save by staying patient till the stream clears?

How can a man's life keep its course

If he will not let it flow?

Those who flow as life flows know

They need no other force:

They feel no wear, they feel no tear,

They need no mending, no repair.

He is hollow, like a valley surrounded by mountains.

He is dim, like stagnant and murky water.

And who is the person who can clear the darkness until it begins to glow?

And who is the person who can purify the murky water until it becomes clear?

And who is the person who can nudge the stagnant along until it begins to move?

The one who follows the principles does not seek fullness.

Since he is not full, when he falls, he can renew himself.

He makes his mind empty like a spacious valley.

He is opaque like muddy water.

There is one who remains still while the mud settles and the water clears itself.

There is one who remains quiet and finds that the moment of action arises of its own accord.

There is one who follows the Tao and does not seek plenitude simply because he is not fulfilled.

RETURNING TO THE SOURCE

Seek to attain an open mind (the summit of vacuity). Seek composure (the essence of tranquillity).

All things are in process, rising and returning. Plants come to blossom, but only to return to the root. Returning to the root is like seeking tranquillity; it is moving towards its destiny.

Having emptied yourself of everything, remain where you are.

All things spring forth into activity with one accord, and wither do we see them return?

After blossoming for a while, everything dies down to its root.

This going back to one's origin is called peace: it is the giving of oneself over to the inevitable.

This giving of oneself over to the inevitable is called preservation.

Be utterly humble

And you shall hold to the foundation of peace.

Be at one with all these living things which, having arisen and flourished,

Return to the quiet whence they came,

Like a healthy growth of vegetation

Falling back upon the root.

Acceptance of this return to the root has been called 'quietism,'

Acceptance of quietism has been condemned as 'fatalism.'

But fatalism is acceptance of destiny

Devote yourself to the goal of achieving absolute serenity,

Aspire to a state of perfect peace.

All things come into existence,

And we see them return.

Look at the things that bloomed and flowered,

Each of them returns to its source.

The return to the source is called serenity,

Which means following destiny,

Following destiny is eternal, it is eternity.

He who knows eternity is enlightened.

He

Do one's best to achieve emptiness.

Hold firmly to stillness.

All things on earth follow the same cycle.

I observe their return.

All the teeming creatures return to their roots.

Returning to the root is called stillness.

Stillness means to return to life.

A return to life means

To move toward destiny is like eternity. To know eternity is enlightenment, and not to recognize eternity brings disorder and evil.

Knowing eternity makes one comprehensive; comprehension makes one broadminded; breadth of vision brings nobility; nobility is like heaven.

The heavenly is like Tao. Tao is the Eternal. The decay of the body is not to be feared.

He who knows this preservation is called enlightened.

He who knows it not continues in misery.

He who knows this preservation is great of soul.

He who is great of soul is prevailing.

Prevailing, he is a king.

Being a king, he is celestial.

Being celestial, he is of Tao.

Being of Tao, he endures for ever: for though his body perish, yet he suffers no hurt.

And to accept destiny is to face life with open eyes,

Whereas not to accept destiny is to face death blindfold.

He who is open-eyed is open-minded-

He who is open-minded is open-hearted,

He who is open-hearted is kingly,

He who is kingly is godly,

He who is godly is useful,

He who is useful is infinite,

He who is infinite is immune,

He who is immune is immortal.

who does not know eternity runs blindly

To his pain and suffering.

Knowledge of eternity, is all-embracing.

Since he embraces everything, he will achieve greatness.

Since he grasps greatness, he can attain perfection.

When he reaches perfection, he will attain supremacy.

When he is supreme, he will come to the Tao.

The person who achieves the Tao exists forever.

Even if his body decays, he will never perish.

constancy.

Understanding constancy means enlightenment.

Not knowing constancy leads to evil deeds.

Knowing constancy is knowing tolerance.

Tolerance is impartiality.

Impartiality is the skilful exercise of kingship.

Kingship is Heaven.

Heaven is Tao.

Tao is eternity.

Until the end of one's own life, one will meet no danger.

SIMPLICITY OF HABIT

When great men rule, subjects know little of their existence. Rulers who are less great win the affection and praise of their subjects. A common ruler is feared by his subjects, and an unworthy ruler is despised.

In the first age of mankind the people recognized their superiors.

In the second age they served and flattered them.

In the third age they feared them,

In the fourth age they

A leader is best

When people barely know that he exists,

Not so good when people obey and acclaim him,

Worst when they despise him.

'Fail to honor people,

The greatest rulers are the ones whose existence the people do not notice at all,

The rulers who are inferior to them are the ones whom the people honor and praise,

And inferior to those are the ones of

The best rulers are those whom the people barely know exist.

The next best are those whom the people love and praise.

Then there are those whom the people fear and despise.

If they do not rule

When a ruler lacks faith, you may seek in vain for it among his subjects.

How carefully a wise ruler chooses his words. He performs deeds, and accumulates merit! Under such a ruler the people think they are ruling themselves.

despised them.

Where faith is lacking it does not inspire confidence.

How careful were they in their expressions!

When they had done a good thing they would say, "How very natural we are!"

They fail to honor you;'

But of a good leader, who talks little,

When his work is done, his aim fulfilled,

They will all say, 'We did this ourselves.'

whom they are afraid,

And inferior to those are the ones whom they despise.

When there is a lack of faith in the ruler,

No one believes in his rule.

Now, learn how much importance must be attributed to words.

the country with faith, the people will not respond to them with trust.

The best rulers do not need to rule the people with words.

If they have accomplished their task, the people will be ruled automatically.

THE PALLIATION
OF THE INFERIOR

When the great Tao
is lost sight of, we
still have the idea of
benevolence and
righteousness.
Prudence and
wisdom come to
mind when we see
great hypocrisy.

When the great Tao
is lost men follow
after charity and duty
to one's neighbours.

When wisdom has
met with honours the
world is full of

When people lost
sight of the way to
live

Came codes of love
and honesty,

Learning came,
charity came,

Hypocrisy took
charge;

When the great Tao
is lost, justice,
righteousness and
good will spring
forth.

When wisdom and
cunning emerge,
hypocrisy raises its
head.

When family ties are
no longer
harmonious,
honoring parents and
caring

When the Tao
disappears, humanity
and justice will
appear by
themselves.

When intelligence
appears, falsity will
appear too.

When

When relatives are!
unfriendly, we still
have the teachings of
filial piety and
paternal affection.
When the state and
the clan are in
confusion and
disorder, we still
have the ideals of
loyalty and
faithfulness.

pretenders.

When family ties are
severed then filial
duty and parental
indulgence take their
place

When a nation is
filled with strife then
do patriots flourish.

When differences
weakened family ties

Came benevolent
fathers and dutiful
sons;

And when lands were
disrupted and
misgoverned

Came ministers
commended as loyal.

for children still
remain.

When a nation is in a
state of confusion
and disorder,
patriotism becomes
evident.

When Tao is present,
equilibrium is
present.

When Tao is lost, the
differences between
things emerge.

relatives fall into
disharmony, filial
piety and
kindheartedness will
appear.

When the country
falls into chaos,
official loyalists will
appear.

RETURN TO
SIMPLICITY

Abandon the show of saintliness and relinquish excessive prudence, then people will benefit a hundredfold.
Abandon ostentatious benevolence and conspicuous righteousness, then people will return to the primal virtues of filial piety and parental affection.

By giving up their self-righteousness and abandoning their wisdom the people would be immensely improved.

Forsaking Charity and Duty to the neighbours, they might revert to their natural relations.

Abandoning excellence and foregoing gain, the people would have no

Rid of formalized wisdom and learning

People would be a hundredfold happier,

Rid of conventionalized duty and honor

People would find their families dear,

Rid of legalized profiteering

People would have no thieves to fear.

Abandon learning,

And grief and sorrow will no longer be known.

Abandon learned volumes, cast off wisdom,

And people will be one hundred times better off.

Abandon righteousness, cast off justice,

And people will return to filial duty and birthing offspring.

Abandon cunning, cast

Eliminate the virtuous man, discard the wise, and the people will benefit a hundredfold.

Eliminate the goodhearted, discard justice, and the people will fulfil their filial duty with kindness.

Eliminate skilled workmen,

Abandon cleverness and relinquish gains, then thieves and robbers will disappear.

Here are three fundamentals on which to depend, wherein culture is insufficient.
Therefore let all men hold to that which is reliable, namely, recognize simplicity, cherish purity, reduce one's possessions, diminish one's desires.

more thieves.

The cultivation of these things has been a failure, therefore they should go back whence they came.

And for you, do come forth in your natural simplicity, lay hold on verities, restrain selfishness, and rid yourself of ambition.

These methods of life have failed, all three,

Here is the way, it seems to me:

Set people free,

As deep in their hearts they would like to be,

From private greeds

And wanton needs.

off avarice,

And bandits and thieves will disappear from the earth.

These four principles, even if they form the foundation of human culture, are not sufficient.

Therefore, here are principles to which people can adhere:

Show integrity, adhere to simplicity,

Restrain selfishness, curtail lusts.

discard profit, and the thief will not appear.

These three exist only as superficial forms.

Therefore this is the teaching to the people:

Embrace the simple, hold the unadorned, remove selfishness, reduce desire.

they need but I seek to avoid it.

I have the mind of a fool, but pure.

Everyone shows their intelligence; I show only stupidity.

Everyone tries to find profit with sharpness; I alone do not find it.

Others' desire has no end; like the sea, they drift without reaching a goal.

Everyone thinks that they are someone; I only think of myself as no one.

I behave differently to all the others, and only treasure being nourished by the mother of all creatures.

THE HEART OF
EMPTINESS

All the innumerable forms of teh correspond to the norm of Tao, but the nature of the Tao's activity is infinitely abstract and illusive. Illusive and obscure, indeed, but at its heart are forms and types. Vague and illusive, indeed, but at its heart is all being.

The greatest virtue is in simply following Tao, the intangible, inscrutable.

Inscrutable, intangible, and yet containing forms.

Intangible, inscrutable, and yet containing things.

Profound and obscure, but having an essence, a veritable essence

The surest test if a man be sane

Is if he accepts life whole, as it is,

Without needing by measure or touch to understand

The measureless untouchable source

Of its images,

The measureless untouchable source

Of its substances,
The

The manifestation of the great virtue is to follow the way of the Tao.

Tao is a thing that is invisible, inaccessible.

Inaccessible, invisible, and yet it has image and form.

Cloudy and obscure, but there is essence in it,

And this essence is

A virtuous person comes into being only according to the Tao.

Tao is something which is obscure and indistinct.

Indistinct and obscure -

yet there is an appearance.

Obscure and indistinct -

yet there is a substance.

Vague and dim -
yet there is an

Unfathomable and obscure, indeed, but at its heart is all spirit, and spirit is reality. At its heart is truth.

From of old its expression is unceasing, it has been present at all beginnings. How do I know that its nature is thus? By this same Tao.

in which is consistence.

From eternity until now its nature has remained unchanged.

It inheres in all things from their beginnings.

How do I know of the origin of things?

I know by Tao.

source which, while it appears dark emptiness,

Brims with a quick force

Farthest away

And yet nearest at hand

From oldest time unto this day,

Charging its images with origin:

What more need I know of the origin

Than this?

absolute truth, and there is belief in it.

From ancient times until now, it has not lost its nameless name,

Through it the source of all things has passed.

How do I know that the source of all things is in it?

From the Tao.

essence within it.

This essence is genuine.

There is truth within it.

Since ancient times until now, its name never forsaken, it stands there to guard all the good deeds.

How do I know all the good deeds are guarded by this Tao?

I know.

INCREASE BY HUMILITY

At that time the deficient will be made perfect; the distorted will be straightened; the empty will be filled; the worn out will be renewed; those having little will obtain and those having much will be overcome.

Therefore the wise man, embracing unity as he does, will become the world's model.

Whosoever adapteth himself shall be preserved to the end.

Whosoever bendeth himself shall be straightened.

Whosoever emptieth himself shall be filled.

Whosoever weareth himself away shall be renewed.

Whosoever humbleth himself shall be exalted.

Whosoever exalteth himself shall be abased.

Therefore doth the Sage cling to simplicity, and is an example to all men.

He is not onstentatious, and therefore he shines.

He is not

'Yield and you need not break:'

Bent you can straighten,

Emptied you can hold,

Torn you can mend;

And as want can reward you

So wealth can bewilder.

Aware of this, a wise man has the simple return

Which other men seek:

Without inflaming

Be modest, and you will remain whole.

Be bent, and you will remain straight.

Be empty, and you will remain full.

Be worn out, and you will remain new.

The one who has little will receive.

The one who has a lot will be enslaved.

Therefore the sage guards the one,

And becomes a paradigm for the world.

He does not expose himself, therefore he shines.

He does not make a good

The tortured will seek for the snug.

The bent will seek for the straight.

The hollow will seek for the full.

The worn will seek for the new.

The minor will seek for the major.

The affluent will seek for the perplexed.

Therefore the virtuous man considers unity as the only model for the world.

He does not flaunt himself, therefore he is brilliant.

Not pushing himself forward he will become enlightened; not asserting himself he will become distinguished; not boasting of himself he will acquire merit; not approving himself he will endure. Forasmuch as he will not quarrel, the world will not quarrel with him.

Is the old saying, "The crooked shall be made straight," a false saying? Indeed, no! They will be perfected and return rejoicing.

egotistic, and therefore he is praised.

He is not vain, therefore he is esteemed.

He is not haughty, and therefore he is honoured.

And because he does not compete with others, no man is his enemy.

The ancient maxim, "Whosoever adapteth himself shall be preserved to the end," verily it is no idle saying.

Without doubt he shall go back to his Home in peace.

himself

He is kindled,

Without explaining himself

Is explained,

Without taking credit

Is accredited,

Laying no claim

Is acclaimed

And, because he does not compete,

Finds peaceful competence.

How true is the old saying,

'Yield and you need not break'!

How completely it comes home!

name for himself, therefore he is known.

He does not praise himself, therefore he is dear to everyone.

He does not glorify himself, therefore his name is on everyone's lips.

And since he does not compete at all,

There is no one in the world who can compete with him.

The ancient ones said:

Be modest, and you will remain whole.

Can these be meaningless words?

Indeed, he will return home whole.

does not consider himself right, therefore he is incontestable.

He does not require his fame, therefore he is meritorious.

He does not stick to his own knowledge, therefore he grows.

Only because he does not fight can no one under Heaven fight with him.

The ancient saying 'The tortured will be made snug' is very well put.

It truly enables one to preserve the unity.

EMPTINESS AND
NOT-DOING (WU
WEI)

Taciturnity is natural to man. A whirlwind never outlasts the morning, nor a violent rain the day. What is the cause? It is heaven and earth. If even heaven and earth are not constant, much less can man be.

Therefore he who pursues his affairs in the spirit of Tao will become Tao-like.

Moderate your speech, and preserve yourself.

A hurricane will not outlast the morning, a heavy rain will not outlast the day.

Who have the power to make these things but Heaven and Earth?

And if Heaven and Earth cannot continue them long, how shall a man do so?

If a man accords with Tao in all things, he is identified with Tao by that

Nature does not have to insist,

Can blow for only half a morning,

Rain for only half a day,

And what are these winds and these rains but natural?

If nature does not have to insist,

Why should man?

It is natural too

That whoever follows the way of life feels alive,

It is natural to be frugal with words.

A gale will not blow for an entire morning;

Pelting rain will not fall for a whole day.

Who causes all those?

Heaven and earth.

If (the fruit of) heaven and earth cannot last forever,

How can man?

The person who follows the Tao,

Is identified with

Nature speaks rarely.

A stormy wind cannot blow for the whole morning, a passing heavy shower cannot fall for the whole day.

Even Heaven and Earth cannot show their sudden power for ever - much less can men.

That is the reason why one who follows the Tao

accords the Tao with the Tao,

accords the virtue with the virtue, accords

He who pursues his affairs with teh, will become teh-like. He who pursues his affairs with loss, identifies himself with loss.

He who identifies himself with Tao, Tao rejoices to guide. He who identifies himself with teh, teh rejoices to reward. And he who identifies himself with loss, loss rejoices to ruin.

If his faith fail, he will receive no reward of faith.

agreement.

A virtuous man is identified with virtue, a vicious man is identified with vice.

Whoever is identified with Tao, him do the Taoists receive with gladness.

Whoever is identified with virtue, him do the virtuous receive with gladness.

But whoever is identified with vice, him do the vicious gladly serve with vice.

For wherever confidence is lacking, it is not met with trust.

That whoever uses it properly feels well used,

Whereas he who loses the way of life feels lost,

That whoever keeps to the way of life

Feels at home,

Whoever uses it properly

Feels welcome,

Whereas he who uses it improperly

Feels improperly used:

'Fail to honor people,

They fail to honor you.

the Tao.

The person who adheres to virtue, Is identified with virtue.

The person who adheres to vice,

Is identified with vice.

When a person follows the Tao,

The Tao looks kindly upon him.

When the person adheres to virtue,

Virtue welcomes him.

When the person adheres to vice,

Vice opens its door to him.

the loss with the loss.

He who accords with the Tao is gladly accepted by the Tao.

He who accords with the virtue is gladly accepted by the virtue.

He who accords with the loss is gladly accepted by the loss.

When there isn't enough faith from he who leads the people, the people who follow him will not have good faith.

TROUBLES AND
MERIT

It is not natural to stand on tiptoe, or being astride one does not walk. One who displays himself is not bright, or one who asserts himself cannot shine.

By standing on tiptoe one cannot keep still.

Astride of one's fellow one cannot progress.

By displaying oneself one does not shine.

By self-approration one is not esteemed.

In self-praise there is no merit.

Standing tiptoe a man loses balance,

Walking astride he has no pace,

Kindling himself he fails to light,

Acquitting himself he forfeits his hearers,

Admiring himself he does so alone.

Pride has never brought

A person who stands on tiptoe cannot stand firmly on his feet.

A person who spreads his legs cannot walk steadily.

A person who displays himself cannot shine (like a star in the sky).

A person who praises himself will not be praised by others.

A person who glorifies himself will not be famous.

A person who

He who tiptoes cannot stand.

He who strides cannot walk.

He who sees only himself is not enlightened.

He who is self-righteous is not notable.

He who boasts about himself will have no merit.

He who

A self-approving man has no merit, nor does one who praises himself grow.

The relation of these things (self-display, self-assertion, self-approval) to Tao is the same as offal is to food. They are excrescences from the system; they are detestable; Tao does not dwell in them.

He who exalts himself does not stand high.

Such things are to Tao what refuse and excreta are to the body.

They are everywhere detested.

Therefore the man of Tao will not abide with them.

a man greatness

But, according to the way of life,

Brings the ills that make him unfit,

Make him unclean in the eyes of his neighbor,

And a sane man will have none of them.

makes himself mighty cannot excel.

All these, in comparison to the Tao, are called:

"A surfeit of food and an excess of action."

They will be tiresome to everyone in other things, too.

Therefore, the man of Tao is not found in their company.

All these are examples of living in a way that goes against nature.

praises himself will have no improvement.

The way he takes the Tao, as if eating with a full stomach and moving with excess baggage, will be disliked.

Therefore he who follows the Tao will not abide this.

DESCRIBING THE MYSTERIOUS

There is Being that is all-inclusive and that existed before Heaven and Earth. Calm, indeed, and incorporeal! It is alone and changeless!

Everywhere it functions unhindered. It thereby becomes the world's mother. I do not know its nature; if I try to characterize it, I will call it Tao.

If forced to give it a name, I will call it the Great.

Before Heaven and Earth existed there was in Nature a primordial substance.

It was serene, it was fathomless.

It was self-existent, it was homogeneous.

It was omnipresent, nor suffered any limitation.

It is to be regarded as the universal mother.

I do not know its name, but I call it Tao.

If forced to qualify it, I call it the boundless.

Being boundless, I call it

Before creation a presence existed,

Self-contained, complete,

Formless, voiceless, mateless,

Changeless,

Which yet pervaded itself

With unending motherhood.

Though there can be no name for it,

I have called it 'the way of life.'

Perhaps I should have called it 'the fullness of life,'

Since fullness implies widening into space,

Implies still further widening,

There is something that is overt and hidden,

That exists beyond heaven and earth.

Formless, motionless,

It stands alone, forever, it does not change,

It exists in every place, it never tires.

It can be called "Mother of the universe,"

Because I don't know its name.

If I am compelled to call it by a name,

I will call it Tao, "all-embracing."

"All-embracing" exists

There is matter formed of confusion, born earlier than Heaven and Earth.

In the silence and the void it stands alone and does not change.

It turns around without worry.

It is capable of being the mother of all creatures under Heaven.

I do not know its name, but call it Tao.

It is compelled to be named 'great'.

'Great'

The Great is evasive, the evasive is the distant, the distant is ever coming near. Tao is Great. So is Heaven great, and so is Earth and so also is the representative of Heaven and Earth.

Man is derived from nature, nature is derived from Heaven, Heaven is derived from Tao. Tao is self-derived.

the inconceivable.

Being inscrutable, I call it the inaccessible.

Being inaccessible, I call it the omnipresent.

Tao is supreme, Heaven is supreme, Earth is supreme, the King is supreme.

There are in the universe four kinds of supremacy, and their rulership is one.

Man is ruled by the Earth, the Earth is ruled by Heaven, Heaven is ruled by Tao, and Tao is ruled by itself.

whole.

In this sense

The way of life is fulfilled,

Heaven is fulfilled,

Earth fulfilled

And a fit man also is fulfilled:

These are the four amplitudes of the universe

And a fit man is one of them:

Man rounding the way of earth,

Earth rounding the way of heaven,

Heaven rounding the way of life

Till the circle is full.

forever,

"All-embracing" is far-reaching,

"All-embracing" returns to every beginning.

Therefore Tao is "all-embracing,"

Heaven is "all-embracing,"

Earth is "all-embracing,"

Man is "all-embracing."

In the universe, four things are "all-embracing,"

And man is one of them.

Man adheres to the laws of earth,

Earth adheres to the laws of heaven,

Heaven adheres to the laws of Tao,

Tao adheres to the laws of its nature.

means passing away,

passing away means far away,

far away means returning.

That is why the Tao is great.

Heaven is great.

Earth is great.

The emperor is great.

Within the realm there are four great things; the emperor is one of the four.

Human beings follow the Earth.

The Earth follows Heaven.

Heaven follows the Tao.

The Tao follows Nature.

THE VIRTUE (TEH) OF DIGNITY

The heavy is the root
of the light; the quiet
is master of motion.
Therefore the wise
man in all the
experience of the day
will not depart from
dignity.

Weight underlies
lightness, quiescence
underlies motion.

Therefore the Sage
never loses his
gravity and
quiescence from day
to day.

Though glorious
palaces should
belong to him, he
would dwell in them

Gravity is the root of
grace,

The mainstay of all
speed.

A traveler of true
means, whatever the
day's pace,

Remembers the
provision-van

And, however fine
prospect be offered,
is

Heaviness is the basis
of lightness,

The passing is the
basis of movement,

Therefore the sage,
even when traveling
all day long,

Never abandons the
baggage wagon,

Therefore the sage,
even when surrounded
by splendor and
luxury,

Is shrouded in
indifference that stems
from serenity.

How can this great
emperor, with a
thousand chariots,

Move easily
throughout his
kingdom?

The heavy is the root
of the light.

Stillness is the
sovereign of restless
movement.

Therefore a virtuous
man will not lose
sight of his
impedimenta during
the whole day.

Although he has
splendour, he

Though he be
surrounded with
sights that are
magnificent, he will
remain calm and
unconcerned.

How does it come to
pass that the
Emperor, master of
ten thousand
chariots, has lost the
mastery of the
Empire? Because
being flippant
himself, he has lost
the respect of his
subjects; being
passionate himself,
he has lost the
control of the
Empire.

peacefully, without
attachment.

Alas that a king with
many chariots should
conduct himself with
frivolity in the midst
of his kingdom!

By levity he loses his
ministers, and by
inconstancy his
throne.

a man

With a calm head.

What lord of
countless chariots
would ride them in
vain,

Would make himself
fool of the realm,

With pace beyond
rein,

Speed beyond helm?

he will lose his basis,

If he is hasty, he will
lose his serenity.

Wang-Pi comments:

The light cannot bear
the heavy; the small
cannot contain the
large; the sedentary
controls the moving,
the one who does not
move from his place
controls the one who
moves from his place.

Therefore heaviness is
the basis of lightness,
and serenity is the
secret of control.

stands aloof.

Unfortunately the
great ruler of ten
thousand chariots
governs the country
indiscreetly.

To act abruptly is to
lose the trust of his
officials.

To act restlessly is to
lose his respect as a
sovereign.

THE FUNCTION OF SKILL

Good walkers leave no tracks, good speakers make no errors, good counters need no abacus, good wardens have no need for bolts and locks for no one can get by them. Good binders can dispense with rope and cord, yet none can unloose their hold.

Therefore the wise man trusting in goodness always saves men, for there is no outcast to him.

A good walker makes no dust after him.

The good speaker incurs no discussion.

The good reckoner needs no arithmetic.

The good keeper needs no bolts or bars, and none can open after him.

The wise man is constant and a good helper of his fellows. He rejects none.

He is a continual good preserver of things.

One may move so well that a foot-print never shows,

Speak so well that the tongue never slips,

Reckon so well that no counter is needed,

Seal an entrance so tight, though using no lock,

That it cannot be opened,

Bind a hold so firm, though using no cord,

That it cannot be untied.

And these are traits not only of a sound man

But of many a

The good traveler leaves no tracks,

The good speaker leaves no doubt,

The good accountant needs no abacus,

The good builder needs no lock and bolt,

And the door he closes will not open behind him.

The good fastener needs no ropes or knots,

And it is still impossible to untie after him.

Even if people are bad, why should they be rejected?

Therefore the sage is always the good savior of the people,

He who knows how to travel does not leave any trace.

He who knows how to use words does not make any errors.

He who knows stratagems needs not any plans.

He who knows how to lock uses no bolts, yet what has been locked cannot be opened.

He who knows how to tie uses no rope, yet what has been tied cannot be released.

Therefore the sage always knows how to take care of

Trusting in goodness he saves all things for there is nothing valueless to him. This is recognizing concealed values.

Therefore the good man is the instructor of the evil man, and the evil man is the good man's wealth. He who does not esteem his instructors or value his wealth, though he be otherwise intelligent, becomes confused. Herein lies the significance of spirituality.

He disdains nothing.

His intelligence is all-embracing.

Good men instruct one another; and bad men are the material they delve in.

Whoever, therefore, does not honour his teacher and cherish his material, though he be called wise, is yet in a state of delusion.

This is no less important than strange.

unsound.

A sound man is good at salvage,

At seeing that nothing is lost.

Having what is called insight,

A good man, before he can help a bad man,

Finds in himself the matter with the bad man.

And whichever teacher

Discounts the lesson

Is as far off the road as the other,

Whatever else he may know.

That is the heart of it.

will reject him.

He is good to all creatures,

He spurns nothing.

This state is called "to see and to come to the light."

Therefore, good people are guides to bad people,

And many people are like matter in good people's hands.

And the person who does not appreciate his guide,

And the person who does not love the matter in his hand,

All their success comes from blindness.

This is the main principle of the secret.

people, and so no one is abandoned.

He knows how to take care of all things, and so no thing is abandoned.

This is what is called following discernment.

That is why good men are the teachers of bad men, and bad men are the sources of warning of good men.

Not to value the teacher, not to care for the sources,

this reveals foolishness, however clever one may be.

RETURNING TO SIMPLICITY

He who knows his manhood and understands his womanhood becomes useful like the valleys of earth (which bring water). Being like the valleys of earth, eternal vitality (teh) will not depart from him, he will come again to the nature of a little child.

He who knows his innocence and recognizes his sin becomes the world's model.

He who, being a man, remains a woman, will become an universal channel.

As an universal channel the eternal virtue will never forsake him. He will re-become a child.

He who, being in the light, remains in obscurity, will become an universal model.

As an universal model the eternal virtue will not pass him by. He will go back to the all-perfect.

He who,

'One who has a man's wings

And a woman's also

Is in himself a womb of the world'

And, being a womb of the world,

Continuously, endlessly,

Gives birth;

One who, preferring light,

Prefers darkness also

Is in himself an image of the world

And, being an image of the world,

Is continuously, endlessly

The person who holds on to masculinity but also preserves femininity

Will be a channel that draws the entire world through it,

And, being a channel for the entire world, will not lack eternal heroism,

And can then return to the purity of his childhood.

The person who holds on to white, but also preserves black

Will be a sign and an example for the world,

And, being a sign and an example for the world, will not lack eternal heroism,

And can then return to

Recognize the male - the yang,

guard the female - the yin.

Be a valley under Heaven.

Be a valley under Heaven and the constant virtue will not fade away.

One will become like a little child again.

Recognize the white - the yang,

guard the black - the yin.

Be a model under Heaven.

Be a model under Heaven and the

Being a world's model, infinite teh will not fail, he will return to the Absolute.

He who knows the glory of his nature and recognizes also his limitations becomes useful like the world's valleys. Being like the world's valleys, eternal teh will not fail him, he will revert to simplicity.

being glorious, continues in humility, will become an universal valley.

As an universal valley the eternal virtue will fill him. He will revert to the first essence.

This first essence is that which, being differentiated, gives rise to innumerable vessels of life.

A wise man, by embracing it, becomes the wisest of governors.

A liberal government is that which neither disregards not hurts anyone.

The dwelling of creation;

One who is highest of men

And humblest also

Is in himself a valley of the world,

And. being a valley of the world,

Continuously, endlessly

Conducts the one source

From which vessels may be usefully filled;

Servants of the state are such vessels,

To be filled from undiminishing supply.

the infinite absolute.

The person who holds on to honor but also preserves humility

Will be a valley that absorbs the whole world into it,

And, being a valley that absorbs the whole world into it, will not lack eternal heroism,

And can then return to fundamental perfection.

Fundamental perfection, when divided up, will become vessels of many uses,

And these will be used by the sage, officers, and ministers.

constant virtue will not fade away.

One will return to the infinite.

Recognize the glory, guard the disgrace.

Be a valley under Heaven.

Be the valley under Heaven and return again to the uncarved block.

When the block is carved up it is transformed into useful wares.

The sage will use them with equal heart.

Therefore the great law will not crumble.

NOT FORCING
THINGS (WU WEI)

One who desires to take and remake the Empire will fail. The Empire is a divine thing that cannot be remade. He who attempts it will only mar it.

He who seeks to grasp it, will lose it.

When a man who wishes to reform the world takes it in hand, I perceive that there will be no end to it!

Spiritual vessels are not fashioned in the world.

Whoever makes destroys; whoever grasps loses.

For perforce if

Those who would take over the earth
And shape it to their will

Never, I notice, succeed.

The earth is like a vessel so sacred

That at the mere approach of the profane

It is marred

And when they reach out their fingers it is gone.

For a time in the world some force themselves ahead

And some are left behind,

For

When a person undertakes to hold and mold the world,
I see that he will fail in this task.

Since the world is an instrument of God:

It cannot be molded,

It cannot be held.

He who tries to mold it damages it,

He who insists on holding it loses it.

Therefore the sage does not mold it, and therefore he does

To rule the country with force is a matter that cannot be avoided - as I see.

Yet to hold the land under Heaven with force cannot be done.

Whoever does it will fail.

Whoever tries to control it will lose it.

If there is something that goes in the front, there will be something that follows behind.

If there is something

People differ, some lead, others follow; some are ardent, others are formal; some are strong, others weak; some succeed, others fail. Therefore the wise man practices moderation; he abandons pleasure, extravagance and indulgence.

one advances another is left behind; if one blows hot another will blow cold; if one be strengthened another will be weakened; is one be supported another will be undermined.

Therefore the Sage gives up all enthusiasm, levity, and pomp.

a time in the world some make a great noise

And some are held silent,

For a time in the world some are puffed fat

And some are kept hungry,

For a time in the world some push aboard

And some are tipped out:

At no time in the world will a man who is sane

Over-reach himself,
Over-spend himself,
Over-rate himself.

not damage it,

He does not try to hold it, and therefore he does not lose it.

With all things, some move forward while others lag behind,

Some hold their tongues, while others speak a lot,

Some are strong, while others are weak,

Some are on the wagon, while others fall off.

Therefore the sage avoids excess, extremism, haughtiness, lust, and arrogance.

that makes warmth, there will be something that cools it down.

If there is something that creates strength, there will be something that makes it weak.

If there is something that reaches its goal, there will be something that breaks it.

Therefore the sage stays away from opposing the rule of Nature,

from seeking luxuriousness, from doing what is against his own duty.

BE STINGY OF
WAR

When the magistrate follows Tao, he has no need to resort to force of arms to strengthen the Empire, because his business methods alone will show good returns.

Briars and thorns grow rank where an army camps. Bad harvests are the sequence of a great war. The good ruler will be resolute and then stop, he dare not take by force.

The man who aids the King by use of Tao forces the people into submission without resort to the use of arms. He will not regard the fruit of his actions.

Prickly briars and thorns flourish where battalions have quartered.

Bad years follow on the heels of armies in motion.

The good soldier is brave when occasion requires, but he does not risk himself

One who would guide a leader of men in the uses of life

Will warn him against the use of arms for conquest.

Weapons often turn upon the wielder,

An army's harvest is a waste of thorns,

Conscription of a multitude of men

Drains the next year dry.

A good general, daring to march, dares also to halt,

Will never press his triumph beyond need.

What

The person who helps a ruler of men with the Tao

Does not force the world with weapons.

He aims only to redeem the Tao,

And does not attempt to force his strength on others.

Bringing redemption, he does not attribute it to himself,

He does not boast much,

The ruler who rules his people with Tao

need not show his force with an army.

If he who rules does so with the force of an army the others will return with the force of an army.

Wherever armies have marched,

thistles and thorns grow.

Whenever a great war has begun,

crop failure and famine follow.

That is why a good ruler would not dare to flaunt the power of his army.

One should be resolute but not boastful; resolute but not haughty; resolute but not arrogant; resolute but yielding when it cannot be avoided; resolute but he must not resort to violence.

By a resort to force, things flourish for a time but then decay. This is not like the Tao and that which is not Tao-like will soon cease.

for power.

Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not oppress.

Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not boast.

Brave is he when occasion requires, but he is not mean.

Brave is he when occasion requires, but he does not rage.

Things become old through excess of vigour. This is called Non-Tao; and what is Non-Tao is soon wasted!

he must do he does but not for glory,

What he must do he does but not for show,

What he must do he does but not for self;

He has done it because it had to be done,

Not from a hot head.

Let life ripen and then fall,

Force is not the way at all:

Deny the way of life and you are dead.

he is not proud,

He thinks that it is his obligation to do so.

This is how redemption will be, without force.

When things reach their full power,

They begin their process of aging.

This goes against the Tao.

Whatever goes against the Tao will quickly come to an end.

the force.

He uses the army, yet with reserve and dignity.

He uses the army, yet with politeness.

He uses the army just because he is forced to do so.

That is what 'to show consideration and not force' means.

A strong army is like a creature in its prime:

it will only grow older.

This is the rule of Tao and that is the reason why one should not oppose the Tao.

AVOIDING WAR

Even successful arms, among all implements, are unblessed. All men come to detest them. Therefore the one who follows Tao does not rely on them. Arms are of all tools unblessed, they are not the implements of a wise man. Only as a last resort does he use them.

Peace and quietude are esteemed by the wise man, and even when victorious he does not rejoice, because rejoicing over a victory is the same as rejoicing over the killing of men. If he rejoices over killing men, do you think he will ever really master the Empire?

Weapons, however ornamental, are not a source of happiness, but are dreaded by all.

Therefore the man of Tao will not abide where such things are.

A respectable man at home sets the place of honour at his left hand; but the warrior on going forth to battle gives honour to the right hand. For weapons are things of ill omen, and the man of enlightenment does not use them except when he cannot help it.

His great desire is peace, and he does not take joy in conquest.

To joy

Even the finest arms are an instrument of evil,

A spread of plague,

And the way for a vital man to go is not the way of a soldier.

But in time of war men civilized in peace

Turn from their higher to their lower nature.

Arms are an instrument of evil,

No measure for thoughtful men

Until there fail all other choice

But sad acceptance of it.

Triumph is not beautiful.

He who

As far as weapons are concerned, they are instruments of suffering.

They are not the instruments of the man of Tao.

For the actions of weapons will be repaid:

In a place where armies are stationed, only thorns and thistles grow.

Years of misery always accompany great wars.

When the man of Tao stays at home,

His left is his place of honor,

And when using weapons,

His right is his place of honor.

He uses weapons

Only when he cannot avoid doing so.

He does not rejoice in his conquests.

If he

Weapons are cursed instruments.

They are something to hate.

Therefore he who holds the Tao will not use them.

A virtuous man keeps to the left position in his daily life, but values the right in times of war.

Weapons are cursed instruments and not made for virtuous men.

He who uses them against his will will handle them with great concern.

One should regard victory as something ugly.

propitious affairs the place

of honor is the left, but in unpropitious affairs we honor the right.

The strong man while at home esteems the left as the place of honor, but when armed for war it is as though he esteems the right hand, the place of less honor.

in conquest is to joy in the loss of human life.

He who joys in bloodshed is not fit to govern the country.

When affairs are prosperous the left side is preferred, but when things are adverse the right is esteemed.

The adjutant-general is therefore on the left side, while the general-in-chief is on the right.

This I perceive is the manner also observed at a funeral!

He who has occasion to kill many people has cause for deep sorrow and tears.

Therefore a victorious army observes the order of a funeral.

thinks triumph beautiful

Is one with a will to kill,

And one with a will to kill

Shall never prevail upon the world.

It is a good sign when man's higher nature comes forward,

A bad sign when his lower nature comes forward,

When retainers take charge

And the master stays back

As in the conduct of a funeral.

The death of a multitude is cause for mourning:

rejoices in his conquests,

It means that he enjoys killing and slaughter.

The person who enjoys killing people,

Cannot realize his aspirations in the world.

In matters of bringing honor, the place of honor is on the left;

In the opposite matters, the place of honor is on the right.

The adjutant-general takes his place on the left,

The general's place is on the right,

And this means that it is a funeral procession.

The slaughter of many people leads to deep and protracted mourning.

Victory in battle is immortalized in a funeral procession.

as beautiful enjoys killing and will not achieve his ambition under Heaven.

A lucky event is honoured by the left position,

an unlucky event by the right.

In preparation for war, a lieutenant stands on the left,

a general stands on the right.

This means that the matter is treated as a funeral.

Cry with sorrow when many people are killed.

Regard it as a period of mourning when the battle is won.

THE VIRTUE (TEH)
OF HOLINESS

Tao in its eternal aspect is unnamable. Its simplicity appears insignificant, but the whole world cannot control it. If princes and kings employ it every one of themselves will pay willing homage. Heaven and Earth by it are harmoniously combined and drop sweet dew.

Tao the absolute has no name.

But although insignificant in its original simplicity, the world does not presume to bemean it.

If a king could lay hold on it, the world would of itself submit to him.

Heaven and Earth would conspire to nourish him.

The peopole without pressure would peacefully fall into

Existence is infinite, not to be defined;

And, though it seem but a bit of wood in your hand, to carve as you please,

It is not to be lightly played with and laid down.

When rulers adhered to the way of life,

They were upheld by natural loyalty:

Heaven and earth were joined and made fertile,

Life was a freshness of rain,

The Tao was always nameless.

When it was expressed for the first time,

It was given a name.

And once it has

The Tao has no name, like an uncarved block.

But no one under Heaven dares claim its allegiance.

Should lords and princes be able to hold fast to it,

the myriad creatures will submit to their own accord.

Heaven and Earth will unite and the sweet dewdrop will fall.

People will

People will have no need of rulers, because of themselves they will be righteous.

As soon as Tao expresses itself in orderly creation then it becomes comprehensible. When one recognizes the presence of Tao he understands where to stop. Knowing where to stop he is free from danger.

To illustrate the nature of Tao's place in the universe: Tao is like the brooks and streams in their relation to the great rivers and the ocean.

their own places.

If he should dispose them by titles and names, he would be making a name for himself.

Yet he would wisely stop short of the name, and thus avoid the evil of distinctions.

Tao is to the world what the streams and valleys are to the great rivers and seas.

Subject to none,
Free to all.

But men of culture came, with their grades and their distinctions;

And as soon as such differences had been devised

No one knew where to end them,

Though the one who does know the end of all such differences

Is the sound man:

Existence

Might be likened to the course

Of many rivers reaching the one sea.

already been given a name, it is necessary to stop.

The knowledge of where to stop makes a person immune to any danger.

live in peace, even though no one is seeking for it.

When the block is carved it will be named.

It will also be time to stop.

Knowing to stop in time avoids danger.

The Tao runs under Heaven as the river and the water of the valley run into the sea.

THE VIRTUE (TEH)
OF
DISCRIMINATION

He who knows others
is intelligent; he who
understands himself
is enlightened; he
who is able to
conquer others has
force, but he who is
able to control
himself is mighty.

He is wise who
knows others.

He who knows
himself is
enlightened.

He is strong who
conquers others.

He who conquers
himself is mighty.

He is rich who

Knowledge studies
others,

Wisdom is
self-known;

Muscle masters
brothers,

Self-mastery is bone;

Content

The person who
knows others is wise,

The person who
knows himself is
enlightened.

The person who
conquers others is
strong,

The person who
conquers himself is
powerful.

The person who
knows his lot is rich.

The person who
maintains his path
with energy has a
strong

He who knows others
is resourceful; he
who knows himself
is enlightened.

He who surpasses
others has power; he
who surpasses
himself is strong.

He who is content is

He who appreciates
contentment is
wealthy.

He who dares to act
has nerve; if he can
maintain his position
he will endure, but
he, who dying does
not perish, is
immortal.

is well satisfied.

He walks fast who
has an object.

He who fills his place
remains secure.

He who dies without
being corrupted
enjoys a good old
age.

need never borrow,

Ambition wanders
blind:

Vitality cleaves to
the marrow

Leaving death
behind.

will.

The person who does
not stray from his
proper place will
have a long life.

The person who dies
but does not perish
will exist forever.

Feo-tzu says:

"The difficulty in
knowing is not
learning others, but
learning ourselves.

Therefore, the person
who learns himself is
enlightened."

rich.

He who keeps going
has will.

He who maintains his
own position will last
long.

He who dies, yet
whose natural
character remains,
will live a long life.

THE PERFECTION
OF TRUST

Great Tao is all pervading! It can be on both the right hand and the left. Everything relies upon it for their existence, and it does not fail them. It acquires merit but covets not the title. It lovingly nourishes everything, but does not claim the rights of ownership.

Mighty Tao is all pervading.

It is simultaneously on this side and on that.

All living things subsist from it, and all are in its care.

It works, it finishes, and knows not the name of merit.

In love it nurtures all things, and claims no

Bountiful life, letting anyone attend,

Making no distinction between left or right.

Feeding everyone, refusing no one,

Has not provided this bounty to show how much it owns,

Has not fed and clad its guests with any thought of claim;

And,

The great Tao is in everything, both on the left and on the right.

Through it, all things come into being, and it does not abandon them.

When its work is completed, it does not possess them.

It loves and nurtures all things,

But

The Tao is floating everywhere, to the left and to the right.

The lives of the myriad creatures depend on it, no one can live without it.

It accomplishes its task, yet claims no honour.

It nourishes the myriad creatures, yet claims no possession.

It

It has no desires, it can be classed with the small. Everything returns to it, yet it does not claim the right of ownership. It can be classed with the great.

Therefore the wise man to the end will not pose as a great man, and by so doing will express his true greatness.

excellence therein.

It knows neither ambition nor desire.

It can be classed with the humblest of things.

All things finally revert to it, and it is not thereby increased.

It can be mentioned with the greatest of things.

Thus does the wise man continually refrain from self-distinction.

because it lacks the twist

Of mind or body in what it has done,

The guile of head or hands,

Is not always respected by a guest.

Others appreciate welcome from the perfect host

Who, barely appearing to exist,

Exists the most.

does not rule them.

It never exists, so it can be called small, apparently.

All things return home to it,

And it does not claim to own them,

So it can be called great, apparently.

It never aspires to greatness,

And therefore it accomplishes greatness.

is always free from desire;

it can be called small.

The myriad creatures turn to it, yet it does not master them; it can be called great.

That is why the sage never boasts to be the great one, therefore he is the great one.

THE VIRTUE (TEH)
OF
BENEVOLENCE

The world will go to him who grasps this Great Principle; they will seek and not be injured, they will find contentment, peace and rest.

Music and dainties attract the passing people, while Tao's reality seen-is insipid.

Attain to the Great Idea, and all the world will flock to you.

It will flock to you and will not be hurt therein, for it will rest in a wonderful peace.

Where there is a festival

If the sign of life is in your face

He who responds to it

Will feel secure and fit

As when, in a friendly place,

Sure of hearty care,
A

The person who holds the great thing

Will go through a whole world.

He will go along the path straightforwardly without seeing danger,

But finds tranquillity, friendship, and equality.

The sounds of a tune and the scent of delicacies will cause the stranger

Embrace the appearance of Tao.

Everyone under the great Heaven will follow it,

yet no one tries to cause harm to it.

Peace and safety and equality will arise.

Banquets and delicacies are like passing guests: they

Indeed it has no taste, when looked at there is not enough seen to be prized, when listened for, it can scarcely be heard, but, the use of it is inexhaustible.

the wayfarer will stay.

To the palate the Tao is insipid and tasteless.

In regarding it the eye is not impressed.

In listening to it the ear is not filled.

But in its uses it is inexhaustible.

traveler gladly waits.

Though it may not taste like food

And he may not see the fare

Or hear a sound of plates,

How endless it is and how good!

passing by to stop.

But Tao, when it is expressed in words, is pure, devoid of all taste.

When someone looks at it, he won't see it.

When someone listens to it, he won't hear it.

However, when someone uses it, it is everything.

cannot last.

The Tao passes the mouth, it cannot be tasted.

The Tao passes the eyes, it cannot be seen.

The Tao passes the ears, it cannot be heard.

Yet it can never be exhausted by use.

EXPLANATION OF
A PARADOX

That which has a tendency to contract must first have been extended; that which has a tendency to weaken itself must first have been strong; that which shows a tendency to destroy itself must first have been raised up; that which shows a tendency to scatter must first have

When Nature is about to withhold a thing it is sure first to increase it.

When about to weaken it is first sure to strengthen.

When about to debase it is certain first to exalt.

When about to deprive it is first sure

He who feels punctured

Must once have been a bubble,

He who feels unarmed

Must have carried arms,

He who feels belittled

Must have been consequential,

He who feels deprived

Must have had privilege,

Whereas

In order to reduce something, it must first be expanded.

In order to weaken something, it must first be strengthened.

In order to drop something, it must first be lifted.

"In order to take, a man must first

To gather things, one must first disseminate them.

To weaken things, one must first strengthen them.

To abolish things, one must first prevail upon them.

To seize things, one must first grant them.

That

been gathered.

This is the explanation of a seeming contradiction: the tender and yielding conquer the rigid and strong (i.e., spirit is stronger than matter, persuasion than force). The fish would be foolish to seek escape from its natural environment. There is no gain to a nation to compel by a show of force.

to give.

This is what I call the covert agreement.

The soft and the weak overcome the hard and the strong.

As a fish out of water is in danger, so a nation is in peril when its armaments are revealed to the people.

a man with insight

Knows that to keep under is to endure.

What happens to a fish pulled out of a pond?

Or to an implement of state pulled out of a scabbard?

Unseen, they survive.

give."

This is what is called the wisdom of light.

The soft and weak can overcome the hard and strong.

Just as the fish should not leave the depths,

The sharp instruments of control should not leave their hiding-place.

is what 'profound understanding' means.

The soft will overcome the hard.

The weak will overcome the strong.

The fish shall not leave deep waters.

The weapons of a country should not be displayed in public.

ADMINISTERING THE GOVERNMENT

Tao is apparently inactive (wu wei) and yet nothing remains undone. If princes and kings desire to keep) everything in order, they must first reform themselves.

Tao remains quiescent, and yet leaves nothing undone.

If a ruler or a king could hold it, all things would of their own accord assume the desired shape.

If in the process of

The way to use life is to do nothing through acting,

The way to use life is to do everything through being.

When a leader knows this,

His land naturally goes straight.

And the

Tao is never active, but there is nothing it does not do.

If princes and kings could hold onto it, all things would develop by themselves.

When they develop, the desire in them would emerge,

I would restrain them with simplicity,

So simple that it does not even have a name,

In order to liberate them from desire.

Free of desire, they would be soaked in tranquillity,

And thus the world would attain purity and virtue.

The Tao always does nothing but nothing remains undone.

If the ruler observes this the myriad creatures will act of their own accord.

After their metamorphosis, desire will arise.

It will press them down

(If princes and kings would follow the example of Tao, then all things will reform themselves.) If they still desire to change, I would pacify them by the simplicity of the ineffable Tao.

This simplicity will end desire, and if desire be absent there is quietness. All people will of themselves be satisfied.

transformation desire should arise, I would check it by the ineffable simplicity.

The ineffable simplicity would bring about an absence of desire, and rest would come back again.

Thus the world would regenerate itself.

world's passion to stray from straightness

Is checked at the core

By the simple unnamable cleanness

Through which men cease from coveting,

And to a land where men cease from coveting

Peace comes of course.

Simplicity, however unimportant it may be,

Cannot be subdued even by the entire world.

If princes and kings could hold onto it,

Everything in the world, of its own accord, would pay homage.

Heaven and earth would unite to sprinkle dew, sweeter than honey, on the ground.

Without anyone ordering them to do so, people would attain harmony by themselves.

With the mission accomplished and the objectives achieved,

with the power of the uncarved block, the Tao.

The nameless uncarved block is free from desire.

Absence of desire will lead to stillness and the world under Heaven will be harmonized by itself.

A DISCUSSION ABOUT TEH

Essential teh makes no show of virtue, and therefore it is really virtuous. Inferior virtue never loses sight of itself and therefore it is no longer virtue. Essential virtue is characterized by lack of self-assertion (wu wei) and therefore is unpretentious. Inferior virtue is acting a part and thereby is only pretense.

Superior benevolence in a way is acting but does not thereby become pretentious. Excessive righteousness is acting and does thereby become pretentious. Excessive propriety is acting, but where no one responds to it, it stretches its arm and enforces obedience.

The superior virtue is not recognized as such, and it is therefore the very essence of virtue.

The inferior virtue has the distinction of virtue, therefore it lacks the essence.

The superior virtue is spontaneous, and makes no claim to merit.

The inferior virtue is designing, and lays claim to recognition.

The higher benevolence acts without pretension to merit.

The inferior justice acts, and also makes pretensions.

The inferior expediency is designing, and therefore no one honours it.

Therefore does it bare its arm and assert itself by force.

A man of sure fitness, without making a point of his fitness,

Stays fit;

A man of unsure fitness, assuming an appearance of fitness,

Becomes unfit.

The man of sure fitness never makes an act of it

Nor considers what it may profit him;

The man of unsure fitness makes an act of it

And considers what it may profit him.

However a man with a kind heart proceed,

He forgets what it may profit him;

However a man with a just mind proceed,

He remembers what it may profit him;

However a man of conventional conduct

Superior virtue is not aware of being a superior virtue,

So it has virtue.

Inferior virtue never discards the virtue,

Therefore it has no virtue.

Superior virtue seems inactive, but it does everything.

Inferior virtue operates, but ultimately its work is incomplete.

Superior love operates without motive.

Superior justice operates without motive.

The superior system operates, even though nothing responds to it at first,

And gradually people raise their arms and join it.

A man of great virtue is not aware of virtue; that is the reason why he has virtue.

A man of little virtue does not miss virtue; that is the reason why he has no virtue.

The great virtue is when one does not do anything, yet everything is done.

The little virtue is when one does everything, yet something remains undone.

A man of great humanity acts, yet he acts without purpose.

A man of great justice acts, yet he acts with purpose.

A man of great courtesy acts, and if no one responds he rolls

one loses Tao there is still teh; one may lose teh and benevolence remains; one may forsake benevolence and still hold to righteousness; one may lose righteousness and propriety remains.

Propriety, alone, reduces loyalty and good faith to a shadow, and it is the beginning of disorder. Tradition is the mere flower of the Tao and had its origin in ignorance.

Therefore the great man of affairs conforms to the spirit and not to external appearance. He goes on to fruitage and does not rest in the show of blossom. He avoids mere propriety and practices true benevolence.

that when virtue is lost, benevolence takes its place.

When benevolence is lost, justice ensues.

When justice is lost, then expediency follows.

But expediency is the mere shadow of what is right and true, and it is portentous of confusion.

Superficial virtue is the mere tinsel of Tao, and the fool makes use of it.

But the truly great man establishes himself on that which is solid, and will not lean upon a shadow.

He keeps to the real, and avoids display.

He rejects the one, and takes the other with both hands.

with

Out goes his fist to enforce compliance.

Here is what happens:

Losing the way of life, men rely first on their fitness;

Losing fitness, they turn to kindness;

Losing kindness, they turn to justness;

Losing justness, they turn to convention.

Conventions are fealty and honesty gone to waste,

They are the entrance of disorder.

False teachers of life use flowery words

And start nonsense.

The man of stamina stays with the root

Below the tapering,

Stays with the fruit

Beyond the flowering:

lost, love is lost.

If love is lost, justice is lost.

If justice is lost, the superior system comes into being.

The superior system, therefore, is the expression of impatience and disloyalty, the result of confusion of the senses.

Knowledge that contains no knowledge is only the flower of Tao and the beginning of folly.

Therefore, the truly great person keeps the concrete and rejects the transient,

He keeps the fruit and does not take the flower.

Therefore he rejects the flower and takes the fruit.

up his sleeves and tries to persuade them to respond.

That is why when the Tao is lost, virtue appears.

When virtue is lost, humanity appears.

When humanity is lost, justice appears.

When justice is lost, courtesy appears.

Courtesy is the superficial form of faith and trust; it is the beginning of disorder.

A man of much knowledge results in the flourishing of the Tao; it is the beginning of foolishness.

Therefore a true man lives with magnanimity, renounces the frivolous, lives with simplicity, renounces the luxuriant.

**AVOIDING
ACTIVITY**

Retirement is
characteristic of Tao
just as weakness
appears to be a
characteristic of its

The path of the Tao
is backward.

The characteristic of
Tao is

Life on its way
returns into a mist,

Its quickness is its
quietness again:

Going back is the
movement of the
Tao,

Weakening is the
expression of the

Returning is the
movement of Tao.

Weakness is the use
of the Tao.

The

activity.

Heaven and earth and
everything are
produced from
existence, but
existence comes from
nonexistence. . . .

gentleness.

Everything in the
universe comes from
existence, and
existence from
non-existence.

Existence of this
world of things and
men

Renews their never
needing to exist.

Tao.

Everything in the
universe springs
from within
existence,

And existence
springs from
non-existence.

myriad creatures
under Heaven are
born from something.

The something is
born from nothing.

THE UNREALITY
OF APPEARANCE

The superior scholar
when he considers
Tao earnestly
practices it; an
average scholar
listening to Tao
sometimes follows it
and sometimes loses
it; an inferior scholar
listening to Tao
ridicules it. Were it
not thus ridiculed it
could not be regarded
as Tao.

Therefore the writer
says: Those who are
most illumined by Tao
are the most obscure.
Those advanced in
Tao are most retiring.
Those best guided by
Tao are the least
prepossessing.

When a wise man
hears the Tao, he
follows it.

When one of average
mind hears it, he holds
to it a while and
presently loses it.

When a foolish man
hears it, he only
laughs at it.

If it were not held in
derision by such men,
it could not rightly be
called Tao.

Therefore, as the
verse-makers would
say:-

Who shines with Tao
is lost in shade;

His path in Tao is
retrograde,

And

Men of stamina,
knowing the way of life,
Steadily keep to it;

Unstable men, knowing
the way of life,

Keep to it or not
according to occasion;

Stupid men, knowing the
way of life

And having once
laughed at it, laugh again
the louder.

If you need to be sure
which way is right, you
can tell by their laughing
at it.

They fling the old
charges:

'A wick without oil,'

'For every step forward a

Non-existence can
penetrate the hardest
of all.

Therefore I know
that there is
usefulness to

A first-rate scholar hears
the Tao and practises it
conscientiously.

A second-rate scholar
hears the Tao and
follows it just at that
moment.

A poor scholar hears the
Tao and laughs out loud.

If the poor scholar does
not laugh, it cannot be
the Tao.

That is why it is said:

One who knows the Tao
clearly seems ignorant.

One who improves
himself according to the
Tao seems backward.

One who moves with the
Tao is equal

high in virtue (teh)
resemble a lowly
valley; the whitest are
most likely to be put
to shame; the broadest
in virtue resemble the
inefficient.

The most firmly
established in virtue
resemble the remiss.
The simplest chastity
resembles the fickle,
the greatest square has
no corner, the largest
vessel is never filled.
The greatest sound is
void of speech, the
greatest form has no
shape. Tao is obscure
and without name, and
yet it is precisely this
Tao that alone can
give and complete.

obscure.

The highest virtue has
no name,

The greatest pureness
seems but shame;

True wisdom seems
the least secure.

Inherent goodness
seems most strange;

What most endures is
changeless Change;

And squareness doth
no angles make.

The largest vessel
none can gird; The
loudest voice was
never heard;

The greatest thing no
form doth take.

step or two back.'

To such laughers a level
road looks steep,

Top seems bottom,

'White appears black,

'Enough is a lack,'

Endurance is a
weakness,

Simplicity a faded
flower.

But eternity is his who
goes straight round the
circle,

Foundation is his who
can feel beyond touch,

Harmony is his who can
hear beyond sound,

Pattern is his who can
see beyond shape:

Life is his who can tell
beyond words

Fulfillment of the
unfulfilled.

non-action.

Learning without
words, usefulness
without action,

Only a few in the
world have achieved
this.

to the Tao.

The highest virtue feels
empty, like the valley.

The purest whiteness
feels tainted.

The brightest virtue
never seems adequate.

He who is virtuous feels
like a thief.

The purest nature seems
polluted.

The truest square has no
corners.

The greatest abilities
mature slowly.

The greatest tone has no
sound.

The greatest shape has
no form.

The Tao hides within the
nameless.

THE
TRANSFORMATION
OF TAO

Tao produces unity;
unity produces
duality; duality
produces trinity;
trinity produces all
things. All things
bear the negative
principle (yin) and
embrace the positive
principle (yang).
Immaterial vitality,
the third principle
(chi), makes them
harmonious.

Tao emanated the One;
the one emanated the
Two; and the two
emanated the Three.

From the Three all
things have
proceeded.

All things are backed
by the Unmanifest
and faced by the
Manifest.

That which unites
them is the
immaterial breath.

Orphanage, isolation,
and a chariot without
wheels are shunned
by the people; but
kings and great

Life, when it came to
be,

Bore one, then two,
then three

Elements of things;

And thus the three
began

-Heaven and earth
and man-

To balance
happenings:

Cool night behind,
warm day ahead,

For the living, for the
dead.

Though a commoner
be loth to say

That he is only

Your reputation or
your person, which is
closer to you?

Your person or your
property, which is
dearer to you?

Profit or loss, which
is worse for you?

Over-eagerness leads
to over-spending.

Too much

The Tao bears the
'One'.

The 'One' bears the
'Two'.

The 'Two' bears the
'Three'.

The 'Three' bears the
myriad creatures.

The myriad creatures
carry yin and
embrace yang, which
both melt into 'chi' -
the energy of life - to
achieve harmony.

People detest above
all orphanhood and
widowhood,

There are some
things which it is a
gain to lose, and a
loss to gain.

I am teaching the
same things which
are taught by others.
But the strong and
aggressive: ones do
not obtain a natural
death (i.e.,
self-confident
teachers do not
succeed). I alone
expound the basis of
the doctrine of the
Tao.

men appropriate
these names to
themselves.

For things increase
by being deprived;
and being added to
they are diminished.

That which people
teach by their actions
I make use of to
instruct them.

Those who are
violent and
headstrong, for
example, do not die a
natural death.

They teach a good
lesson, and so I make
use of them.

common clay,

Kings and princes
often state

How humbly they are
leading,

Because in true
succeeding

High and low
correlate.

It is an ancient
thought,

Which many men
have taught,

That he who
over-reaches

And tries to live by
force

Shall die thereby of
course,

And is what my own
heart teaches.

property leads to too
much loss.

Therefore, the person
who is content with
his lot will not know
disgrace,

And the person who
knows where to stop
will never disappear,

He will exist forever.

yet the rulers use
these titles to
describe themselves.

That is why in losing
much is gained, and
in gaining much is
lost.

What others teach, I
teach also:

He who is a ferocious
adversary does
nothing else but
cause his own death.

With these words I
will maintain my
teaching.

THE FUNCTION
OF THE
UNIVERSAL

The most tender
things of creation
race over the hardest.

A non-material
existence enters into
the most
impenetrable.

I therefore recognize
an advantage in the
doctrine of not doing
(wu wei) and not
speaking.

The gentlest thing in
the world will
override the
strongest.

The Non-Existent
pervades everything,
though there be no
inlet.

By this I

As the soft yield of
water cleaves
obstinate stone,

So to yield with life
solves the insoluble:

To yield,

When the learned scholar
hears the Tao

He makes every effort to
master it.

When the mediocre scholar
hears the Tao

It will seem as if he grasps
and loses it, alternately.

When the weak scholar
hears the Tao

He laughs wildly,

If he had not laughed at it, it
would not be worthy to be
Tao.

Therefore it is written:

"The enlightened Tao
seems dark,

The advanced Tao seems
backward,

The direct Tao seems
obscure,

The most exalted quality
looks like a valley,

The most pristine

The softest under
Heaven can ride
roughshod over the
hardest.

That without
substance can enter
even into the smallest
space.

That is why I

But there are few in
the world who obtain
the advantage of
non-assertion (wu
wei) and silence.

comprehend how
effectual is
non-action.

To teach without
words and to be
useful without action,
few among men are
capable of this.

I have learned, is to
come back again.

But this unworded
lesson,

This easy example,
Is lost upon men.

white looks colorless,

The most superior virtue
looks insufficient,

The most solid quality is
like a fragile stalk,

The simplest nature looks
changeable,

The largest square has no
angles,

The largest vessel is never
whole,

The loudest sound is hardly
heard,

The largest image cannot be
imagined.

Tao, since it is hidden, is
nameless."

But only the Tao can
improve and mend.

To separate is to be
constructive; to be
constructive is to be
destructive.

All things, whether they are
constructive or destructive,
lead to the One again.

know the benefit of
doing nothing.

Teaching without
words, benefiting
without doing:

there are
unfortunately very
few people under
Heaven who can
reach these goals.

PRECEPTS

Which is nearer, a name or a person?
Which is more, personality or treasure? Is it more painful to gain or to suffer loss?
Extreme indulgence certainly greatly wastes.

Which is neared to you, your name or your person?
Which is more precious, your person or your wealth?
Which is the greater evil, to gain or to lose?
Great

Which means more to you,
You or your renown?
Which brings more to you,
You or what you own?
And which would cost you more
If

Tao begets one,
One begets two,
Two begets three,
Three begets all things.
All things, back to the shade, front to the light,
The harmony between them is

Fame or your self: which is dearer?
Your self or your possessions: which is more precious?
To have or to lose: which is more detrimental?
That is why the most beloved will cost a

Much hoarding certainly invites severe loss.
A contented person is not despised. One who knows when to stop is not endangered; he will be able therefore to continue.

devotion requires great sacrifice.
Great wealth implies great loss.
He who is content can never be ruined.
He who stands still will never meet danger.
These are the people who endure.

it were gone?
The niggard pays,
The miser loses.
The least ashamed of men
Goes back if he chooses:
He knows both ways,
He starts again.

the breath of life.
What others teach, I also teach:
"The cruel and violent do not die a natural death."
I will use that sentence as my guide.

great deal.
The more one stores, the more one will lose.
He who is content will not meet disgrace.
He who knows when to stop will not face danger.
Only then is there longevity.

THE VIRTUE (TEH)
OF GREATNESS

Extreme perfection
seems imperfect, its
function is not
exhausted. Extreme
fullness appears
empty, its function is
not exercised.

Extreme straightness
appears crooked;
great skill, clumsy;
great eloquence,
stammering.

He who sees that his
highest attainments
are always
incomplete may go
on working
indefinitely.

He who sees his
greatest possessions
to be inadequate may
go on acquiring
forever.

His highest

A man's work,
however finished it
seem,

Continues as long as
he live;

A man, however
perfect he seem,

Is needed as long as
he live:

As long as truth
appears falsity,

The seer a fool,

The greatest
perfection looks
flawed,

And even so, it never
perishes.

The greatest fullness
looks empty,

And even so, it will
never run out.

The straightest road
looks crooked.

The

Great achievement
seems imperfect, yet
its usefulness is not
diminished.

Great fullness seems
empty, yet it is
inexhaustible.

Great frankness
seems

Motion conquers
cold, quietude
conquers heat. Not
greatness but purity
and clearness are the
world's standard.

rectitude is but
crookedness.

His greatest wisdom
is but foolishness.

His sweetest
eloquence is but
stammering.

Action overcomes
cold; inaction
overcomes heat.

With virtue and
quietness one may
conquer the world.

The prophet a dumb
lout,

If you want to keep
warm keep stirring
about,

Keep still if you want
to keep cool,

And in all the world
one day no doubt

Your way shall be
the rule.

greatest vigor looks
like laziness,

The greatest
eloquence looks like
stammering.

Action overcomes
cold,

Tranquillity
overcomes heat.

Only through purity
and tranquillity of
spirit

Can order be
imposed on the
world.

to succumb.

Great discussion
seems silent.

Activity overcomes
coldness.

Stillness overcomes
heat.

Purity and stillness
are the ideal for the
world.

LIMITATION OF
DESIRE

When the world
yields to Tao, race
horses will be used to
haul manure. When
the world ignores
Tao war horses are
pastured on the
public common.

When Tao is in the
world, horses are
used in the
pastureland.

When Tao has left
the world, chargers
are reared in the
wilderness.

There is no greater
sin

In a land where the
way of life is
understood

Race-horses are led
back to serve the
field;

In a land where the
way of life is

When Tao rules the
world

Racehorses are
harnessed to the
garbage cart in the
fields.

When Tao does not
rule the world

War-horses graze in
the meadows on the
outskirts of the city.

There is no greater
sin than going after
what man desires,

There is

When there is Tao
under Heaven,
fleet-footed horses
are working in the
fields.

When there is no Tao
under Heaven, war
horses appear outside
the city.

There is no greater
crime

There is no sin
greater than desire.
There is no
misfortune greater
than discontent.
There is no calamity
greater than
acquisitiveness.
Therefore to know
extreme contentment
is simply to be
content.

than indulging desire.

There is no greater
pain than discontent.

There is nothing
more disastrous than
the greed of gain.

Hence the
satisfaction of
contentment is an
everlasting
competence.

not understood

War-horses are bred
on the autumn yield.

Owning is the
entanglement,

Wanting is the
bewilderment,

Taking is the
presentiment:

Only he who
contains content

Remains content.

no greater sorrow
than not knowing a
measure of
contentment,

There is no greater
obstacle than falling
into the pit of greed.

Therefore, it is
sufficient for you to
know a measure of
contentment in order
to know contentment
in proportion, so as
to satisfy your
measure.

than having wrong
desires.

There is no greater
hardship than being
discontent.

There is no greater
misfortune than
obtaining one's own
triumph.

That is why he who
feels content is
always content.

SEEING THE
DISTANT

Not going out of the door I have knowledge of the world. Not peeping through the window I perceive heaven's Tao.

A man may know the world without leaving his own home.

Through his windows he can see the supreme Tao.

The further afield he goes

There is no need to run outside

For better seeing,

Nor to peer from a window. Rather abide

At the center of your being;

For the more

Without crossing the threshold of the gate

It is possible to know the entire world.

Without looking through the window

It is possible to see the Tao of heaven.

Without going outside

one can know the whole world.

Without looking out of the window

one can see the Tao of Heaven.

The more one wanders to a distance the less he knows.

Therefore the wise man does not wander about but he understands, he does not see things but he defines them, he does not labor yet he completes.

the less likely is he to find it.

Therefore the wise man knows without travelling, names things without seeing them, and accomplishes everything without action.

you leave it, the less you learn.

Search your heart and see

If he is wise who takes each turn:

The way to do is to be.

The further the person goes,

The less he knows.

Therefore the sage

Knows everything without going through the streets,

Names everything without seeing it,

Accomplishes every task without doing anything.

The further one goes, the less one knows.

Therefore the sage

without walking, knows everything,

without seeing, identifies everything,

without doing, accomplishes everything.

TO FORGET
KNOWLEDGE

He who attends daily to learning increases in learning. He who practices Tao daily diminishes. Again and again he humbles himself. Thus he attains to non-doing (wu wei).

Bodily and mental distress is increased every day in the effort to get knowledge.

But this distress is daily diminished by the getting of Tao.

Do you continually curtail your effort till there be nothing left of

A man anxious for knowledge adds more to himself every minute;

A man acquiring life loses himself in it,

Has less and less to bear in mind,

Less and less to do, Because life, he finds, is

The person who pursues his studies

Will be wiser with every passing day,

The person who seeks the Tao

Will decrease with every passing day.

Less and less, he will continue to decrease,

Until he reaches the state of non-action,

And by non-action

In the course of learning, one increases every day.

In the course of Tao, one decreases every day.

Decreasing and decreasing, until doing nothing.

Doing nothing, yet everything

He practices non-doing and yet there is nothing left undone.

To command the empire one must not employ craft. If one uses craft he is not fit to command the empire.

it?

By non-action there is nothing which cannot be effected.

A man might, without the least distress, undertake the government of the world.

But those who distress themselves about governing the world are not fit for it.

well inclined,

Including himself too.

Often a man sways the world like a wind

But not by deed;

And if there appear to you to be need

Of motion to sway it, it has left you behind.

it is possible to do everything.

Li Chia-mou said:

"He who pursues learning acquires knowledge; he who seeks the Tao casts off his ignorance.

The more the person knows, the more he has to get rid of.

Therefore, adding means nothing more than decreasing."

is done.

That is why he who aims at rulership should let things take their course.

Should he try to interfere, he is not worthy of aiming at rulership.

THE VIRTUE (TEH)
OF TRUST

The wise man has no fixed heart; in the hearts of the people he finds his own. The good he treats with goodness; the not-good he also treats with goodness, for teh is goodness.

The wise man has no fixed opinions to call his own.

He accommodates himself to the minds of others.

I would return good for good; I would also return evil for evil.

Virtue is good.

I would meet trust with trust; I

A sound man's heart is not shut within itself

But is open to other people's hearts:

I find good people good,

And I find bad people good

If I am good enough;
I

The sage has no self that he can call "mine,"

He turns the self of the people into his own.

I act with goodness toward the good,

I act with goodness toward the bad, too,
And so the good is contagious.

I relate with trust to the person who is worthy of trust,

I relate with trust

The sage has no mind of his own.

He takes the minds of the people as his own.

Whatever others like, he likes too.

Whatever others dislike, he likes too.

This is what is meant by virtuous goodness.

Whatever others trust, he trusts too.

Whatever others mistrust, he trusts

The faithful ones he treats with good faith; the unfaithful he also treats with good faith, for teh is good faith.

The wise man lives in the world but he lives cautiously, dealing with the world cautiously. He universalizes his heart; the people give him their eyes and ears, but he treats them as his children.

would likewise meet suspicion with confidence.

Virtue is trustful.

The wise man lives in the world with modest restraint, and his heart goes out in sympathy to all men.

THE people give him their confidence, and he regards them all as his children.

trust men of their word,

And I trust liars

If I am true enough;

I feel the heart-heats of others

Above my own

If I am enough of a father,

Enough of a son.

to the person who is not worthy of trust, too,

And so trust is contagious.

The sage lives in the world in his victory and rules the world with his simplicity.

But when all the people look at him and listen to him,

The sage takes care of them, like a mother takes care of her children.

too.

This is what is meant by virtuous trust.

The sage leads his life with vigilance.

He merges his mind with all others' under Heaven.

People are used to hearing and seeing the behaviour of the sage and so they are influenced, and become pure again, as a newborn child.

ESTEEM LIFE

Life is a going forth;
death is a returning
home. Of ten, three
are seeking life, three
are seeking death,
and three are dying.
What is the reason?
Because they live in
life's experience.
(Only one is
immortal.)

I hear it said that the
sage when he travels
is never attacked by
rhinoceros or tiger,
and when coming
among soldiers does
not fear their
weapons.

Men go forth from
Life and enter into
Death.

The Gates of Life are
thirteen in number;
and the same are the
Gates of Death.

By as many ways
does life pass quickly
into Death. And
wherefore?

Because men strive
only after the
Sensuous Life.

It has been said that
one who knows how
to safeguard Life can
go

Death might appear
to be the issue of life,

Since for every three
out of ten being born

Three out of ten are
dying.

Then why

Should another three
out of ten continue
breeding death?

By use of sheer
madness to multiply.

But there is one out
of ten, they say,

It is easy to hold
something that is
motionless,

It is easy to create a
mold for something
that is not lacking,

It is easy to break
something that is
breakable,

It is easy to scatter a
thing that is small.

Take care

Emotions and
longings are life.

Passions and desires
are death.

There are thirteen
kinds of life:

seven are emotions
and they refer to the
gates of the mind;

six are longings and
they refer to the gates
of the body.

There are also
thirteen kinds of
death:

seven are passions
and they refer to the
gates of the mind;

six are desires and
they refer to the gates
of the body.

The rhinoceros
would find no place
to horn him, nor the
tiger a place for his
claws, nor could
soldiers wound him.
What is the reason?
Because he is
invulnerable.

through the country
without protection
against the
rhinoceros and tiger.

He may enter into
battle without fear of
the sword.

The rhinoceros finds
no place wherein to
drive his horn.

The tiger finds no
place wherein to fix
his claws.

The sword finds no
place wherein to
thrust itself.

Why is this?

It is because he has
overcome Death.

so sure of life

That tiger and wild
bull keep clear of his
inland path.

Weapons turn from
him on the
battle-field,

No bull-horn could
tell where to gore
him,

No tiger-claw where
to tear him,

No weapon where to
enter him.

And why?

Because he has no
death to die.

of a thing before it
happens,

Arrange a thing
before it gets out of
hand.

The simple man
generally fails in his
affairs on the verge
of success.

Take care of the end
as you do of the
beginning,

And you will not fail.

of life and death rule
also human beings,
because one treasures
life.

He who is good at
conserving his life
will not meet the
rhinoceros and the
tiger on his journey.

He can enter a battle
without being hurt.

The rhinoceros
cannot attack him
with its horn,

the tiger cannot
scratch him with its
claws,

troops cannot use
their swords against
him.

TEH AS A NURSE

Tao gives life to all creatures; teh feeds them; materiality shapes them; energy completes them. p. 37 Therefore among all things there is none that does not honor Tao and esteem teh. Honor for Tao and esteem for teh is never compelled, it is always spontaneous.

Tao brings forth and Teh nourishes.

All things take up their several forms, and natural forces bring them to perfection.

Therefore all things conspire to exalt Tao and to cherish virtue.

But this regard of Tao and Teh is not in deference to

Existence having born them

And fitness bred them,

While matter varied their forms

And breath empowered them,

All created things render, to the existence and fitness they depend on,

An obedience

Not commanded but of course.

And since this

The Tao created all things,

The way of the Tao nourished them,

All things emerge in different forms,

Each of them is perfect in the nature of the Tao within it.

Therefore, there is not one among the myriad of things

That does not honor the Tao and cherish its way.

Honoring the Tao and cherishing its way are not dictated by law,

But rather come from within.

The Tao creates.

The virtue nourishes.

The things form.

The environment shapes them to completion.

That is why the myriad creatures all respect the Tao, and value virtue.

When the Tao is respected, virtue is valued.

No one can command them but the Tao.

That

Therefore Tao gives life to them, but teh nurses them, raises them, nurtures, completes, matures, rears, protects them.

Tao gives life to them but makes no claim of ownership; teh forms them but makes no claim upon them, raises them but does not rule them. This is profound vitality (teh).

any mandate.

It is unconstrained, and therefore it endures forever.

For Tao produces all things, and Teh nourishes, increases, feeds, matures, protects, and watches over them.

To produce without possessing; to work without expecting; to enlarge without usurping; this is the absolute virtue!

is the way existence bears issue

And fitness raises, attends,

Shelters, feeds and protects,

Do you likewise

Be parent, not possessor,

Attendant, not master,

Be concerned not with obedience but with benefit,

And you are at the core of living.

Tao creates them, makes them grow, nourishes them,

Guards them, lifts them, and protects them.

When all things are created, the Tao does not reject them.

It creates them without owning them.

It operates without depending on them, and raises them without controlling them.

When its work is completed, it does not lay any claim to them.

is why the Tao creates myriad creatures.

Virtue nourishes them, cultivates them, educates them, completes them, ripens them, supports them, carries them.

The Tao creates them without possessing them, benefits them without profiting from them, guides them without commanding them.

That is what profound virtue means.

RETURN TO ORIGIN

When creation began, Tao became the world's mother. When one knows one's mother he will in turn know that he is her son. When he recognizes his sonship, he will in turn keep to his mother and to the end of life will be free from danger.

He who closes his mouth and shuts his sense gates will be free from trouble to the end of life.

That from which the universe sprang may be looked upon as its Mother.

By knowing the Mother you have access to the child.

And if, knowing the child, you prefer the Mother, though your body perish, yet you will come to no harm.

Keep your mouth shut, and close up the doors of sight and sound, and as long as

The source of life

Is as a mother.

Be fond of both mother and children but know the mother dearer

And you outlive death.

Curb your tongue and senses

And you are beyond trouble,

Let them

People leave life and enter death.

Life's portion is three out of ten.

Death's portion is also three out of ten.

People who move from the day of birth into the realm of death,

Their portion is also three out of ten.

Why is that?

Because of their futile efforts to seek eternal life.

However, only those who do nothing to prolong their life,

Are better off than those who do everything in order to live longer.

The world had a beginning.

This beginning is the mother of the world.

Once you know the mother

you know the children.

When you know the children

you will return to embrace the mother.

Then you will live lifelong without danger.

Close the mouth, and the spirit will not escape.

Seal the ears, and the mind will not escape.

You will

He who opens his mouth and meddles with affairs cannot be free from trouble even to the end of life.

To recognize one's insignificance is called enlightenment. To keep one's sympathy is called strength. He who uses Tao's light returns to Tao's enlightenment and does not surrender his person to perdition. This is called practicing the eternal.

you live you will have no vexation.

But open your mouth, or become inquisitive, and you will be in trouble all your life long.

To perceive things in the germ is intelligence.

To remain gentle is to be invincible.

Follow the light that guides you homeward, and do not get lost in the darkness.

This I call using the eternal.

loose

And you are beyond help.

Discover that nothing is too small for clear vision,

Too insignificant for tender strength~

Use outlook

And insight,

Use them both

And you are immune:

For you have witnessed eternity.

knows how to preserve his life

When traveling the earth,

Will not encounter a rhinoceros or a tiger,

And when he goes into battle,

He will not be wounded by a weapon or an arrow.

The rhinoceros will not target him with its horn,

The tiger will not tear him apart with its claws,

Weapons will not find their mark on his body

Where they can pierce him with their blades and arrowheads.

Why is that?

live lifelong without struggle.

Open the mouth, and take action for every matter, and you will live lifelong beyond hope.

To see the small is called clarity.

To know how to yield is called strength.

Use virtue outside the mind but return to virtue in the mind,

and you will live lifelong without danger.

This is what is called practising constancy.

GAIN BY INSIGHT

Even if one has but a little knowledge he can walk in the ways of the great Tao; it is only self-assertion that one need fear.

The great Tao (Way) is very plain, but people prefer the bypaths.

Ah that I were wise enough to follow the great Tao!

Administration is a great undertaking.

The great Tao is extremely simple, but the people prefer the complex ways.

While the palace is extremely well appointed, the fields may

If I had any learning
Of a highway wide and fit,

Would I lose it at each turning?

Yet look at people spurning

Natural use of it!

See how fine the palaces

And see how poor the farms,

How bare the peasants' granaries

While gentry wear

The beginning of the universe, when materialized, is considered to be a mother.

When a man finds the mother, he will know the children, accordingly.

Even though he knows the children, he still clings to the mother:

Therefore, although his body wanes, he never perishes.

The person who shuts his mouth and closes his doors

Will never

Should I know just a fraction of Tao,

I would walk on the great way, fearing to impose upon the people.

The main road is smooth to walk but the people prefer the smaller footpath.

That is why the court is

When the palace is very splendid, the fields are likely to be very weedy, and the granaries empty. To wear ornaments and gay colors, to carry sharp swords, to be excessive in eating and drinking, and to have wealth and treasure in abundance is to know the pride of robbers. This is contrary to Tao.

be full of tares, and the granaries may be empty.

To dress grandly, to carry sharp swords, to eat and drink excessively, and to amass great wealth, this I call stylish theft.

That it is not Tao is certain.

embroideries

Hiding sharpened arms,

And the more they have the more they seize,

How can there be such men as these

Who never hunger, never thirst,

Yet eat and drink until they burst!

There are other brigands, but these are the worst

Of all the highway's harms.

perish.

If he opens his mouth and increases his affairs,

He will never be saved.

The person who sees the tiniest thing possesses clear vision,

The person who adheres to the weak possesses strength.

Use your light, but dim your brightness,

In this way you will not do yourself any harm.

This is called following the eternal Tao.

corrupt,

the fields lie in waste, the granaries are empty.

Yet the rulers wear clothes adorned with finery,

carry sharp swords decorated with patterns,

possess storehouses overflowing with goods and wealth.

This is to rule by stealing.

This is not the Tao.

TO CULTIVATE
INTUITION

The thing that is well planted is not easily uprooted. The thing that is well guarded is not easily taken away. If one has sons and grandsons, the offering of ancestral worship will not soon cease.

He who practices Tao in his person shows that his *teh* is real. The family that practices it shows that their *teh* is abounding. The township that practices it shows that their *teh* is enduring.

He who plants rightly never uproots.

He who lays hold rightly never relinquishes.

His posterity will honour him continually.

Whoever develops the Tao in himself will be rooted in virtue.

Whoever develops the Tao in his family will cause his virtue to spread.

Whoever develops the Tao in his village will increase prosperity.

'Since true foundation cannot fail

But holds as good as new,

Many a worshipful son shall hail

A father who lived true.'

Realized in one man, fitness has its rise;

Realized in a family, fitness multiplies;

Realized in a village, fitness gathers weight;

Realized in a country, fitness becomes great;

Realized in the

Let me have knowledge and follow the great way of the Tao,

I alone am afraid of straying from this path.

The great way is easy and simple,

But people prefer byways.

The royal palaces are wonderfully maintained,

But the people's fields are full of thorns,

And the barns

He who is well established cannot be uprooted.

He who is holding tight cannot slip away.

His descendants will never cease to honour him.

He who cultivates the moral character, his virtue will be clear.

He who cultivates his own family, his virtue will flourish.

He who cultivates the village, his virtue will endure.

He who cultivates the country, his virtue will be abundant.

He who

The state that practices it shows that their *teh* is prolific. The empire that practices it reveals that *teh* is universal. Thereby one person becomes a test of other persons, one family of other families, one town of other towns, one county of other counties, and one empire of all empires.

How do I know that this test is universal? By this same Tao.

good fortune prevail.

Whoever develops Tao in the world will make virtue universal.

I observe myself, and so I come to know others.

I observe my family, and all others grow familiar.

I study this world, and others come within my knowledge.

How else should I come to know the laws which govern all things, save thus, that I observe them in myself?

world, fitness fills the skies.

And thus the fitness of one man

You find in the family he began,

You find in the village that accrued,

You find in the country that ensued,

You find in the world's whole multitude.

How do I know this integrity?

Because it could all begin in me.

are empty.

There are those who wear expensive clothes,

There are those who carry polished swords,

There are those who gorge themselves on food and drink,

There are those who amass property and possessions:

This is called encouraging the robbers.

Is this not straying from the path of the Tao?

cultivates the land, his virtue will be widespread.

Therefore look at others as at your own person.

Look at other families as at your own family.

Look at other villages as at your own village.

Look at other countries as at your own country.

Look at other lands as at your own land.

How do I know it is like this under Heaven?

By means of this.

TO VERIFY THE
MYSTERIOUS

The essence of teh is comparable to the state of a young boy. Poisonous insects will not sting him, wild beasts will not seize him, birds of prey will not attack him. The bones are weak, the muscles are tender, it is true, but his grasp is firm.

He does not yet know the relation of the sexes, but he has perfect organs, nevertheless. His spirit is virile, indeed!

The man who is saturated with Virtue is like a little child.

Scorpions will not sting him, wild beasts will not seize him, nor will birds of prey pluck at him.

His young bones are not hard, neither are his sinews strong, yet his grasp is firm and sure.

He is full of vitality, though unconscious of his sex.

Though he should cry out all day, yet he is never hoarse.

He whom life fulfills, Though he remains a child,

Is immune to the poisonous sting

Of insects, to the ravening

Of wild beasts or to vultures' bills.

He needs no more bone or muscle than a baby's for sure hold.

Without thought of joined organs, he is gender

Which grows firm, unfaltering.

What is sown by the best sower will never be uprooted,

What is fastened by the best fastener will never be loosened.

And so his children and grandchildren can continue the ancestral ritual for many generations.

If he nurtures the Tao by himself, his virtue is genuine,

If he nurtures the Tao in his family, his virtue is abundant,

If he nurtures the Tao in his village, his virtue is inestimable,

If he nurtures the Tao

He who cherishes deep virtue is comparable to a newborn baby.

Poisonous insects will not sting him.

Ferocious animals will not pounce upon him.

Predatory birds will not swoop down upon him.

His bones are weak and his muscles are soft.

He does not know of the union between male and female.

He has the highest spirit.

He can cry all day but

He can sob and cry all day without becoming hoarse, his harmony (as a child) is perfect indeed!

To recognize this harmony (for growth) is to know the eternal'. To recognize the eternal is to know enlightenment. To increase life (to cause things to grow) is to know blessedness. To be conscious of an inner fecundity is strength. Things fully grown are about to decay, they are the opposite of Tao. The opposite of Tao soon ceases.

Herein is shown his harmony with Nature.

The knowledge of this harmony is the eternal Tao.

The knowledge of the eternal Tao is illumination.

Habits of excess grow upon a man, and the mind, giving way to the passions, they increase day by day.

And when the passions have reached their climax, they fall.

This is against the nature of Tao.

rasp but would stay tender

Through the perfect balancing

Of a man at endless ease with everything

Because of the true life that he has led.

To try for more than this bodes ill.

It is said, 'there's a way where there's a will,'

But let life ripen and then fall.

Willis not the way at all:

Deny the way of life and you are dead.

in his country, his virtue fills the country,

If he nurtures the Tao in the world, his virtue fills the universe.

Therefore, when you observe the individual, know individuals,

When you observe the family, know families,

When you observe the village, know villages,

When you observe the country, know countries,

When you observe the world, know the universe.

How do I know that it is possible to rule the world with the Tao?

never become hoarse.

He has perfect harmony.

He knows harmony as constancy.

He knows constancy as clarity.

To nourish the body with abundant food and clothing means to borrow the outer energy.

To command the 'chi' with the mind means to use force.

When reaching their prime, creatures begin to age.

He who tries to oppose this rule means to go against the Tao.

THE TEH OF THE
MYSTERIOUS

The one who knows
does not speak; the
one who speaks does
not know. The wise
man shuts his mouth
and closes his gates.

He who knows the
Tao does not discuss
it, and those who
babble about it do not
know it.

To keep the lips
closed, to shut the
doors of sight and
sound, to smooth off
the corners, to temper
the glare, and to

Those who know do
not tell,

Those who tell do not
know.

Not to set the tongue
loose

But to curb it,

Not to have edges
that catch

But to remain
untangled,

Unblinded,

Unconfused,

The person who is
blessed with great
virtue can be
compared to a child.

He will not be bitten
by an insect or a
snake,

He will not be
devoured by wild
animals,

Birds of prey will not
swoop down on him.

His bones are fragile,
his tendons soft, but
his grip is strong.

He is not familiar with
the union of man and
woman, but he
possesses
reproductive

One who knows does
not speak.

One who speaks does
not know.

He closes his mouth,
seals his ears.

He subdues his
sharpness, releases
his worries.

He blends himself
with the light, he
becomes one with the
dust.

This is what is called
mysterious identity.

He softens his
sharpness, unravels
his tangles, dims his
brilliancy, and
reckons himself with
the mysterious.

He is inaccessible to
favor or hate; he
cannot be reached by
profit or injury; he
cannot be honored or
humiliated. Thereby
he is honored by all.

be on a level with the
dust of the earth, this
is the mysterious
virtue.

Whoever observes
this will regard alike
both frankness and
reserve, kindness and
injury, honour and
degradation.

For this reason he
will be held in great
esteem of all men.

Is to find balance,

And he who holds
balance beyond sway
of love or hate,

Beyond reach of
profit or loss,

Beyond care of
praise or blame,

Has attained the
highest post in the
world.

powers.

This means that he is
at the peak of his
vitality.

He can weep all day
and not become
hoarse.

This means that he is
in perfect harmony.

Being familiar with
this harmony brings
him closer to eternity,

Being familiar with
eternity enables man
to attain
enlightenment.

Increasing life invites
trouble,

Let your heart become
addicted to the breath
of the spirit, and you
will be filled with
potency.

Therefore he regards
things out of his
reach as dear.

He regards things out
of his reach as
distant,

he perceives
unreachable things
with harm,

he perceives
unreachable things
with value,

he perceives
unreachable things
with humbleness.

That is why he values
everything under
Heaven.

THE HABIT OF SIMPLICITY

The empire is administered with righteousness; the army is directed by craft; the people are captivated by non-diplomacy. How do I know it is so? By this same Tao.

Among people the more restrictions and prohibitions there are, the poorer they become. The more people have weapons, the more the state is in confusion. The more people are artful and cunning the more abnormal things occur.

The righteous man may rule the nation.

The strategic man may rule the army.

But the man who refrains from active measures should be the king.

How do I know this:-

When the actions of the people are controlled by prohibited laws, the country becomes more and more impoverished.

When the people are allowed the free use of arms, the Government is in danger.

The more crafty and dexterous the people

A realm is governed by ordinary acts,

A battle is governed by extraordinary acts;

The world is governed by no acts at all.

And how do I know?

This is how I know.

Act after act prohibits

Everything but poverty,

Weapon after weapon conquers

Everything but chaos,

Business after business provides

A craze of

Make all the weapons blunt,

Cut everything that is tangled,

Make everything that is shiny dull,

Mix with anything that is as humble as dust,

And this is called absolute equality.

Therefore

One cannot get close to it

Nor can one

Govern the nation with correctness.

Resort to arms with surprise manoeuvres.

Obtain the land under Heaven without tiring out the people.

How do I know this?

Because:

The more rules there are in the country,

the poorer the people will become.

The more power the people hold,

the more confused the country will become.

The more skills and intelligence the people possess,

The more laws and orders are issued the more thieves and robbers abound.

Therefore the wise man says: If a ruler practices wu wei the people will reform of themselves. If I love quietude the people will of themselves become righteous. If I avoid profit-making the people will of themselves become prosperous. If I limit my desires the people will of themselves become simple.

become, the more do artificial things come into use.

And when those cunning arts are publicly esteemed, then do rogues prosper.

Therefore the wise man says:-

I will design nothing; and the people will shape themselves.

I will keep quiet; and the people will find their rest.

I will not assert myself; and the people will come forth.

waste,

Law after law breeds

A multitude of thieves.

Therefore a sensible man says:

If I keep from meddling with people, they take care of themselves,

If I keep from commanding people, they behave themselves,

If I keep from preaching at people, they improve themselves,

If I keep from imposing on people, they become themselves.

get away from it.

It is impossible to derive benefit from it,

Nor to be harmed by it.

It does not publicize a person's honor,

Nor does it publicize a person's shame.

Therefore it is the most exalted thing in the world.

become,

yet the more thieves and robbers will breed.

That is why the sage says:

'I do nothing, and the people are nurtured by themselves.'

'I do not tire people and drain the treasury, and the people become rich by themselves.'

'I prefer quietness, and the people behave correctly by themselves.'

'I have no desire, and the people return to the simple life by themselves.'

'I have no emotions, and the people become pure by themselves.'

ADAPTATION TO CHANGE

When an
administration is
unostentatious the
people are simple.
When an
administration is
inquisitive, the
people are needy.
Misery, alas,
supports happiness.
Happiness, alas,
conceals misery.
Who knows its
limits? It never
ceases. The normal
becomes the
abnormal.

A free and generous
government gives the
people a chance to
develop.

When a government
is rigid and exacting
the people are
cramped and
miserable.

Misery is but the
shadow of happiness.

Happiness is but the
cloak of misery.

When will there be
an end to them?

If we dispense with
rectitude, distortion
will assert itself; and
what was good in its
way will

The less a leader
does and says

The happier his
people,

The more a leader
struts and brags

The sorrier his
people.

Often what appears
to be unhappiness is
happiness

And what appears to
be happiness is
unhappiness.

Who can see what
leads to what

When happiness
appears and yet is
not,

When what

Although the wise man
rules the country with
integrity,

And wages war cunningly,

He who wishes to rule the
empire

Must not interfere with
anything.

His wish is unattainable in
any other way.

How do I know this?

Thus:

The more limitations and
prohibitions there are,

The more poor people there
will be.

The more weapons people
possess,

The more riots there will be
throughout the country.

The more artists and
artisans there are among the
people,

The greater the desire to
create things that belong to
the imagination.

When the
government is
unobtrusive, the
people will be simple
and honest.

When the
government is
dictatorial, the people
will be seized with
panic.

Fortune depends on
misfortune.

Misfortune is hidden
in fortune.

He who knows how
to stay within the
limits will not have
misfortune.

Correctness will

The good in turn
becomes unlucky.
The people's
confusion is felt daily
for a long time.

Therefore the wise
man is square, yet
does not injure, he is
angular but does not
annoy. He is upright
but is not cross. He is
bright but not
glaring.

give place to what is
evil.

Verily the people
have been under a
cloud for a long time.

Therefore the wise
man is full of
rectitude, but he does
not chirp and carve at
others.

He is just, but he
does not admonish
others.

He is upright, but he
does not straighten
others.

He is enlightened,
but he does not
offend with his
brightness.

should he is nothing
but a mask

Disguising what
should not be? Who
can but ask

An end to such a
stupid plot!

Therefore a sound
man shall so square
the circle

And circle the square
as not to injure, not
to impede:

The glow of his life
shall not daze,

It shall lead.

rules and regulations there
are,

The more robbers and
thieves there will be.

Therefore the sage says:

When I choose non-action
of my own accord,

The people reach the path
of their own accord.

When I love peace and
quiet of my own accord,

The people behave with
integrity of their own
accord.

When I desist from all
occupation of my own
accord,

The people become very
wealthy of their own
accord.

When I am free of all desire
of my own accord,

The people remain simple
of their own accord.

lead to deceit.

Good will lead to
evil.

Nothing can remain
always the same.

People have been
confused by this
since ancient times.

That is why the sage

behaves correctly
without hurting
others,

behaves honestly
without damaging
others,

behaves
straightforwardly
without vilifying
others,

TO KEEP TAO

In governing the people and in worshipping heaven nothing surpasses moderation. To value moderation, one must form the habit early. Its early acquisition will result in storing and accumulating vitality. By storing and accumulating vitality nothing is impossible.

If nothing is impossible then one is ignorant of his limits.

In ruling men and in serving Heaven there is nothing like moderation.

By means of it one attains to his first estate.

When this is attained a man is possessed of an indefinite store of virtue.

With such a store of virtue he will overcome everything.

And of

To lead men and serve heaven, weigh the worth

Of the one source:

Use the single force
Which doubles the strength of the strong

By enabling man to go right, disabling him to go

When the government is indifferent and inactive,

The people will be happy and wealthy,

When the government discriminates and divides,

The people will be restless and dissatisfied.

Happiness is borne on the back of sorrow,

Sorrow dwells beneath happiness.

Therefore, who can know the virtues of good government?

The best way to rule the people and serve Heaven is to be frugal.

To be frugal means to return to the beginning of creation.

To know the beginning of creation means to accumulate virtue.

Accumulating virtue means to overcome everything.

To overcome

If one does not know his limitations, one may possess the state. He who possesses moderation is thereby lasting and enduring. It is like having deep roots and a strong stem. This is of long life and enduring insight the Tao (way).

this mastery there will be no limit.

Thus, without hindrance, he may possess the Kingdom.

Such a man has the mother-constitution, and will endure indefinitely.

He is like the plant whose roots are deep and whose stem is firm.

Thus may a man live long and see many days.

wrong,

Be so charged with the nature of life that you give your people birth,

That you mother your land, are the fit
And ever-iving root of it:

The seeing.root,
whose eye is infinite.

Otherwise, the rectification becomes a strategy,

And good becomes evil.

People have been aware of this for a long time.

Therefore the sage is square and does not cut others,

He has a point, but he does not pierce others,

He is straight, but he does not straighten others,

He shines, but he does not dazzle others.

everything means to reach the limit.

By reaching the limit, one can possess a kingdom.

When one has possessed the mother of the kingdom,

the kingdom will then live long.

This is called the deep-rooted foundation.

This is the way to long life.

TO MAINTAIN
POSITION

One should govern a great state as one fries small fish (i.e., do not scale or clean them).

With Tao one may successfully rule the Empire.

The state should be governed as we cook small fish, without much business.

Bringing the Tao to the governing of the Kingdom will give rest to the shades of the dead.

Not that the Spirits will be inactive, but they

Handle a large kingdom with as gentle a touch as if you were cooking small fish.

If you manage people by letting them alone,

Ghosts of the dead shall not haunt you.

Not that

When ruling people, like serving heaven, the sage acts only in moderation.

Only with moderation can he learn the Tao in an instant.

This study is called "the rapid accumulation of a virtue."

Through the rapid accumulation of a virtue

He can overcome everything.

Since there is nothing he cannot overcome,

No

Governing a large country is like cooking a small fish.

It is spoiled by too much interference.

When the ruler presents his country with Tao, Heaven will not harm him.

Not only will the curse not fall upon him,

Ghosts will not frighten, gods will not harm, neither will wise men mislead the people. Since nothing frightens or harms the people, they will abide.

will cease to trouble the people.

But what is of more importance, the wise ruler of the people will not hurt them.

And in so far as they do not interfere with one another, their influences conspire to the general good!

there are no ghosts

But that their influence becomes propitious

In the sound existence of a living man:

There is no difference between the quick and the dead,

They are one channel of vitality.

one can know of his superiority.

Since no one knows of his superiority,

He can rule the country.

Since what he does when he acquires everything is identified with the mother, his days are extended.

Thus his roots are deep and his foundations strong, and he knows the way of longevity and immortality.

but it will not even cause harm to the people.

As the curse will not hurt the people, neither will the sage cause harm to the people.

Only because they do not hurt one another, will they blend their virtue.

THE TEH OF HUMILITY

A great state that is useful is like a bond of unity within the Empire; it is the Empire's wife.

The female controls the male by her quietude and submission. Thus a great state by its service to smaller states wins their allegiance. A small state by submission to a great state wins an influence over them.

The kingdom, like a river, becomes great by being lowly; it is thereby the centre to which all the world tends.

It is similar in the case of woman:

She conquers man by continual quietness.

And quietness is the same as submission.

Therefore a great state, by condescension to those beneath it, may gain the government of them.

Likewise

A large country is the low level of interflowing rivers.

It draws people to the sea-end of a valley

As the female draws the male,

Receives it into absorbing depth

Because depth always absorbs.

And so a large country, inasfar as it is deeper than a small country,

Absorbs the small-

Or a small country, inasfar as

Govern a large country as you would cook a small fish, gently.

Let the Tao govern the world, and spirits will not roam freely.

This does not mean that spirits will not have powers,

But rather that their powers will not harm people.

They will

When a large country is like water, which runs towards lower places,

all the other countries will unite with it.

In the unity of the world, the female always overcomes the male with stillness.

The stillness is akin to the lower position - that is how a large country can be respected by a small country and conquer it.

And if a small country takes the lower position

Thus some stoop to conquer, and others stoop and conquer.

Great states can have no higher purpose than to federate states and feed the people. Small states can have no higher purpose than to enter a federation and serve the people. Both alike, each in his own way, gain their end, but to do so, the greater must practice humility.

a small state, by submission to one that is greater, may secure its alliance.

Thus the one gains adherence, and the other obtains favours.

Although the great state desires to annex and to nourish others, yet the small state desires to be allied to and serve the greater.

Thus both will be satisfied, if only the greater will condescend.

it is deeper than a large country,

Absorbs the large.

Some countnes consciously seek depth into which to draw others.

Some countries naturally have depth into which to draw others:

A large country needs to admit,

A small country needs to emit,

And so each country can naturally have what it needs

If the large country submit.

not harm people,

Nor will the sage harm people.

When neither he nor they harm anybody,

The virtue belongs to both of them.

When the Tao governs the world, the spirits are not known as spirits and the sage is not considered a sage, says Wang-Pi.

and allows itself to be influenced by the large country, the small can conquer the large.

That is why by being lower to take, or lower to be taken,

a large country only tries to annex a small one and a small country only tries to protect its people.

They both find what they want.

Therefore it is fitting for a large country to be the lower one.

THE PRACTICE OF TAO

The Tao is the asylum of all things; the good man's treasure, the bad man's last resort. With beautiful words one may sell goods but in winning people one can accomplish more by kindness. Why should a man be thrown away for his evil?

Tao is the secret guardian of all things.

It enriches the good man and forbids the evildoer.

Its counsel is always in season; its benevolence is always in demand.

Even those who are not good it does not forsake.

Therefore, when the Emperor takes his throne and appoints his nobles, he who comes before him bearing the insignia of a prince

Existence is sanctuary:

It is a good man's purse,

It is also a bad man's keep.

Clever performances come dear or cheap,

Goodness comes free;

And how shall a man who acts better deny a man who acts worse

This right to be.

Rather, when an emperor is crowned, let the three

Ministers

A great country is like the drainage basin of the entire world,

Into which all the rivers flow,

It is the field of the entire world,

It is the femininity of the entire world.

Femininity always overcomes masculinity with its calmness of spirit,

Which it uses as a means to lower itself.

Thus the great country lowers itself before the small country,

Before it conquers the small country.

The Tao is the mystery of the myriad creatures.

It is the treasure of good men.

It is the protection of bad men.

Beautiful words of Tao can reach a high rank.

Respectful deeds of Tao can raise a man above others.

Even if a man is not good, why should he be abandoned?

That is why when the emperor takes office and the three ducal

To conserve him was the Emperor appointed and the three ministers.

Better than being in the presence of the Emperor and riding with four horses, is sitting and explaining this Tao.

The reason the Ancients esteemed Tao was because if sought it was obtained, and because by it he that hath sin could be saved. Is it not so? Therefore the world honors Tao.

and escorted by a mounted retinue is not to be compared with one who humbly presents this Tao.

For why did the ancients hold it in such esteem?

Was it not because it could be had without much seeking, and because by means of it man might escape from sin?

For this it was esteemed the greatest thing in the world.

whom he appoints to receive for him fine horses and gifts of jade

Receive for him also the motionless gift of integrity,

The gift prized as highest by those ancients who said,

'Only pursue an offender to show him the way.'

What men in all the world could have more wealth than they?

before a great country,

Before it conquers the great country.

Therefore some lower themselves to take,

And others lower themselves to gather.

The only wish of a great country is to hold on to and keep its endless subjects,

And the only wish of a small country is to engage in many occupations and tasks.

When they both wish to realize their aspirations,

ministers are appointed, although gifts such as the ceremonial jade and the carriage and horses are usually given, it is better to offer the Tao.

And the Tao has been valued since ancient times,

so why shouldn't the emperor seek for it every day?

If he can follow this Tao, all sins will be absolved.

That is why the most valuable thing under Heaven is Tao.

A
CONSIDERATION
OF BEGINNINGS

One should avoid assertion (wu wei) and practice inaction. One should learn to find taste in the tasteless, to enlarge the small things, and multiply the few. He should respond to hatred with kindness. He should resolve a difficulty while it is easy, and manage a great thing while it is small.

Acting without design, occupying oneself without making a business of it, finding the great in what is the small, and the many in the few, repaying injury with kindness, effecting difficult things while they are easy, and managing great things in their beginnings, is the method of Tao.

All difficult things have their origin in that which

Men knowing the way of life

Do without acting,

Effect without enforcing,

Taste without consuming;

'Through the many they find the few,

Through the humble the great;'

They 'respect their foes,'

They 'face the simple fact before it becomes involved,

Solve the small problem before it becomes big.'

The most involved fact in the world

Could have been faced when it was simple,

The Tao is the source of everything,

The treasure of the good man,

The sustainer of the bad man.

Therefore,

Even the ceremonial splendor of the coronation of the emperor and his three ministers,

And the value of the jewels and the knights' horses,

Are nothing compared to the splendor of this

Do that which takes no action.

Deal with that which engenders no effort.

Taste that which has no flavour.

Treat the small as the great.

Return enmity with virtue.

Plan the difficult as the easy.

Carry out the hard work as if it were the finer details.

The difficult things under Heaven come from the

Surely all the world's difficulties arose from slight causes, and all the world's great affairs had small beginnings.

Therefore the wise man avoids to the end participation in great affairs and by so doing establishes his greatness.

Rash promises are lacking in faith and many things that appear easy are full of difficulties. Therefore the wise man considers every thing difficult and so to the end he has no difficulties.

is easy, and the great things in that which is small.

Therefore the wise man can accomplish great things without even attempting them.

He who lightly assents will seldom keep his word.

He who accounts all things easy will have many difficulties.

Therefore the Sage takes great account of small things, and so never has any difficulty.

biggest problem in the world

Could have been solved when it was small.

The simple fact that he finds no problem big

Is a sane man's prime achievement.

If you say yes too quickly

You may have to say no,

If you think things are done too easily

You may find them hard to do:

If you face trouble sanely

It cannot trouble you.

Tao.

Why did the ancients value the Tao?

Is it because it is possible to seek it and find it and liberate sinners with it?

For this reason, the Tao is the most valuable thing in the world.

Good words will nurture our honor,

Good deeds will give a person a good name.

easy things.

Great matter is made up of minor matter.

Therefore the sage does not try to be great, and thus he can be great.

He who makes easy promises can be little trusted.

He who considers things to be easy will meet many difficulties.

That is why the sage expects difficulties, and therefore encounters none.

CONSIDER THE
INSIGNIFICANT

That which is at rest is easily restrained, that which has not yet appeared is easily prevented. The weak is easily broken, the scanty is easily scattered. Consider a difficulty before it arises, and administer affairs before they become disorganized. A tree that it takes both arms to encircle grew from a tiny rootlet. A pagoda of nine stories was erected by placing small bricks. A journey of three thousand miles begins with one step. If one tries to improve a thing, he mars it; if he seizes it, he loses it.

What is small is easily held.

What is expected is easily provided for.

What is brittle is easily broken.

What is small is soon dispersed.

Transact your business before it takes shape.

Regulate things before confusion begins.

The tree which fills the arms grew from a tender shoot.

The castle of nine storeys was raised on a heap of earth.

The journey of a thousand miles begins with one step.

Whoever designs only destroys.

Whoever grasps, loses.

Before it move, hold it,

Before it go wrong, mould it,

Drain off water in winter before it freeze,

Before weeds grow, sow them to the breeze.

You can deal with what has not happened, can foresee

Harmful events and not allow them to be.

Though-- as naturally as a seed becomes a tree of arm-wide girth-

There can rise a nine-tiered tower from a man's handful of earth

Or here at your feet a thousand-mile journey have birth,

Quick action bruises,

Quick grasping loses.

Do a non-deed,

Do a non-action,

Taste tastelessness.

The sage desires non-desire,

And does not value anything rare.

He learns the unlearnable,

But peruses what others have discarded.

Thus he enables all things

To develop in their natural way,

And he does not engage in hasty action.

See the small as big,

See the little as a lot.

Take care of the difficult when it is still easy,

Take care of the big when it is still small.

All difficult things in the world begin as easy things,

All big things in

It is easy to control a situation when it is tranquil.

It is easy to deal with a matter before the omen is cast.

It is easy to break something when it is fragile.

It is easy to scatter something when it is minute.

Deal with things before they arise.

Govern a situation before it descends into disorder.

A huge tree as great as a man's arm-span grows from a tiny seed.

A nine-storey terrace rises from a pile of earth.

A thousand-mile journey starts from a single footstep.

He who acts to reach something will lead to its decline.

He who tries

The wise man, therefore, not attempting to form things does not mar them, and not grasping after things he does not lose them. The people in their rush for business are ever approaching success but continually failing. One must be as careful to the end as at the beginning if he is to succeed.

He does not grasp, and therefore he never loses.

But the common people, in their undertakings, fail on the eve of success.

If they were as prudent at the end as they are at the beginning, there would be no such failures.

Therefore the Sage is only ambitious of what others despise, and sets no value on things difficult to obtain.

He acquires no common learning, but returns to that which people have passed by.

Thus he aims at simple development in all things, and acts without design.

man's care is not to exert

One move that can miss, one move that can hurt.

Most people who miss, after almost winning,

Should have 'known the end from the beginning.'

A sane man is sane in knowing what things he can spare,

In not wishing what most people wish,

In not reaching for things that seem rare.

The cultured might call him heathenish,

This man of few words, because his one care

Is not to interfere but to let nature renew

The sense of direction men undo.

the world begin as small things.

The tree whose trunk cannot be encircled by a man's arms began as a sapling,

A nine-story tower rose from a heap of dirt,

A thousand-mile journey began with the earth under a man's foot.

Therefore the sage does not try to do big things,

And in that way can achieve greatness.

The person who makes casual promises

Will not keep them.

The person who perceives many things as easy

Will encounter many difficulties.

Therefore the sage perceives things as difficult,

And consequently never encounters difficulties.

hard to hold on to something will lose it.

That is why the sage does nothing, and leads nothing to decline.

He does not hold on to anything, therefore he does not lose anything.

People often lead their actions to the verge of success, then fail.

Be careful to treat the end with equal care as the beginning.

Then you will not fail.

Therefore the sage desires not to desire, not to value precious goods,

to learn how not to learn, to cover the mistakes of the multitude,

to assist the myriad creatures according to the law of Nature.

Yet he dares not act.

THE TEH OF
SIMPLICITY

In the olden days
those who obeyed the
spirit of Tao did not
enlighten the people
but kept them simple
hearted.

The reason people
are difficult to
govern is because of
their smartness;
likewise to govern a
people with guile is a
curse; and to govern
them with simplicity
is a blessing.

The ancients who
practiced the Tao did
not make use of it to
render the people
brilliant, but to make
them simple and
natural.

The difficulty in
governing the people
is through overmuch
policy.

He who tries to
govern the kingdom
by policy is only a
scourge to it; while
he

Sound old rulers, it is
said,

Left people to
themselves, instead

Of wanting to teach
everything

And start the people
arguing.

With mere
instruction in
command,

So that people
understand

Less than they know,
woe is the land;

But happy the land
that is ordered so

That they

In ancient times, the
best Tao practitioners
did not use it to
educate the people,
But rather to restore
them to simplicity.

It is difficult to
govern people since
they are very
knowledgeable.

Therefore, ruling a
country by increasing
knowledge

Means destroying the
country,

While ruling a
country by reducing

In ancient times,
those who knew well
how to serve the Tao
did not use it to
enlighten the people
but to fool them.

People are difficult to
govern only because
they are intelligent
and resourceful.

Therefore to rule
with intelligence
harms the country.

To govern the
country

He who remembers
these two things is a
model ruler. Always
to follow this
standard and rule is
teh, the profound.

Profound teh is deep
indeed and far
reaching. The very
opposite of common
things, but by it one
obtains obedient
subjects.

who governs without
it is a blessing.

To know these two
things is the perfect
knowledge of
government, and to
keep them
continually in view is
called the virtue of
simplicity.

Deep and wide is this
simple virtue; and
though opposed to
other methods it can
bring about a perfect
order.

understand more than
they know.

For everyone's good
this double key

Locks and unlocks
equally.

If modern man would
use it, he

Could find old
wisdom in his heart

And clear his vision
enough to see

From start to finish
and finish to start

The circle rounding
perfectly.

knowledge

Means blessing the
country.

The person who is
aware of these two
ways knows the
standard,

The person who
keeps the standard in
his mind is virtuous.

The highest virtue is
profound and broad,

It goes back to the
beginning of
everything,

And in this way
attains absolute
peace.

without intelligence
is a blessing for the
nation.

He who knows the
difference, knows the
principle.

To know the
principle is called
mysterious virtue.

Mysterious virtue is
deep and far.

It might at first seem
to go against the
natural order but it
will then lead to
harmony.

TO SUBORDINATE
SELF

The reason rivers and seas are called the kings of the valley is because they keep below them.

Therefore the wise man desiring to be above his people must in his demeanor keep below them; wishing to benefit his people, he must ever keep himself out

That by which the great rivers and seas receive the tribute of all the streams, is the fact of their being lowly; that is the cause of their superiority.

Thus the Sage, wishing to govern the people, speaks of himself as beneath them; and wishing to lead them,

Why are rivers and seas lords of the waters?

Because they afford the common level

And so become lords of the waters.

The common people love a sound man

Because he does not talk above their level,

Because,

The best soldier does not love war,

The best warrior is not bloodthirsty,

The best conqueror does not take part in the war,

The best employer places himself beneath

Rivers and seas can be king of the hundred valleys,

only because they accept their lower position.

Therefore they can be king of the hundred valleys.

That is why the sage

who wishes to rule the people

must stay beneath them,

who wishes to lead the people

must follow behind them.

of sight.

The wise man dwells above, yet the people do not feel the burden; he is the leader and the people suffer no harm. Therefore the world rejoices to exalt him and never wearies of him.

Because he will not quarrel with anyone, no one can quarrel with him.

places himself behind them.

So, while he is yet above them, they do not feel his weight; and being before them, he yet causes no obstruction.

Therefore all men exalt him with acclamation, and none is offended.

And because he does not strive, no man is his enemy.

though he lead them,

He follows them,

He imposes no weight on them;

And they in turn, because he does not impede them,

Yield to him, content:

People never tire of anyone

Who is not bent upon comparison.

his workers.

That is called the virtue of self-control,

That is called the ability to be helped by others,

That is called the enlightenment that comes from uniting with heaven.

In this way the sage stays above the people,

yet does not oppress them.

He stays ahead of the people,

yet does not exhaust them.

Then the people will support him with joy and never tire of following him.

And because he does not fight, no one can fight against him.

THREE TREASURES

All the world calls
Tao great, yet it is by
nature immaterial. It is
because a thing is
seemingly unreal that
it is great. If a man
affects to be great,
how long can he
conceal his
mediocrity?

Tao has three
treasures which he
guards and cherishes.
The first is called
compassion; the
second is called
economy; the third is
called humility.

All the world avows
that while my Taoism
is great, it is yet
incompetent!

It is its greatness
which makes it appear
incompetent.

If it were like others, it
would long ago have
been recognized as
incompetent.

But I hold fast to three
precious things, which
I also cherish.

The first is gentleness.

The second is
economy.

The third is humility.

With such gentleness I
can be daring.

With such

Everyone says that my
way of life is the way
of a simpleton.

Being largely the way
of a simpleton is what
makes it worth while.

If it were not the way
of a simpleton

It would long ago
have been worthless,

These possessions of a
simpleton being the
three I

choose

And cherish:

To care,

To be fair,

What the Tao is to
the world,

So the streams and
valleys are to the
rivers and seas.

Rivers and seas can
be like kings to all
the streams and
valleys

Since the former can
lower themselves
before the latter.

Thus they are the
kings of all the
streams and valleys.

Therefore the sage, in
order to be above the
people,

Must lower himself
before them in
words,

And in

The whole world says
that the Tao is great,
and that it seems
without form.

It is great - that is why
it has no form.

It has existed for a
long time, and can
also seem small.

I have three treasures
that I keep and
protect:

the first is
goodheartedness,

the second is frugality,

the third is not daring
to take the lead.

Only

A man that is
compassionate can 'be
truly brave; if a man is
economical he can be
generous; if he is
humble he can
become a useful
servant.

economy I can be
generous.

With such humility I
can be great in
service, as a vessel of
honour.

But in these days men
forsake gentleness and
become only
obtrusive.

They abandon
economy and become
only excessive.

They relinquish
humility and strive for
precedence, and thus
for death.

Gentleness is ever
victorious in attack
and secure in defence.

To be humble.

When a man cares he
is unafraid

When he is fair he
leaves enough for
others,

When he is humble he
can grow;

Whereas if, like men
of today, he be bold
without caring,

Self-indulgent without
sharing,

Self-important
without shame,

He is dead.

The invincible shield

Of caring

Is a weapon from the
sky

Against being dead.

order to head the
people,

He must place
himself behind them
in body.

Thus, when he is
above the people, the
people do not suffer
at his hand,

When he is at the
head of the people,
the people are not
held back by him.

Therefore the whole
world wants to carry
him on its shoulders

And never tires of
him.

He competes with
nobody,

goodheartedness can
bring courage.

Only frugality can
bring generosity.

Not daring to take the
lead can bring
leadership.

Now to give up
goodheartedness for
courage, frugality for
generosity, the rear for
the lead,

will surely lead to the
end.

Goodheartedness in
battle will lead to
victory,

and defence will
strengthen the
territory.

COMPLIANCE
WITH HEAVEN

He who excels as a soldier is the one who is not warlike; he who fights the best fight is not wrathful; he who best conquers an enemy is not quarrelsome; he who

The good commander is not imperious.
The good fighter is not wrathful.
The greatest conqueror does not wage war.
The best master governs by condescension.
This

The best captain does not plunge headlong
Nor is the best soldier a fellow hot to fight.
The greatest victor wins without a battle:
He who overcomes men

The whole world tells me:
"Great as the Tao is, it has no form."
Since it is great,
It has no form.
If it resembled any form,
It would have waned a long time ago.
I have three treasures that I keep and safeguard:
The first is called love,
The second is called moderation,
The third is called not jumping to the head of the entire world.
With love, a person can be courageous,
With moderation, a person can be generous,
And

The perfect warrior does not flaunt his bravery.
The perfect fighter does not get angry.
The perfect winner does not reveal his tactics.
The perfect employer is humble before his employees.
This

best employs people is obedient himself.
This is the virtue of not-quarreling, this is the secret of bringing out other men's ability, this is complying with Heaven. Since of old it is considered the greatest virtue (teh).

is the virtue of not contending.
This is the virtue of persuasion.
This is the imitation of Heaven, and this was the highest aim of the ancients.

understands them.
There is a quality of quietness
Which quickens people by no stress:
'fellowship with heaven,' as of old,
Is fellowship with man and keeps its hold.

by not jumping to the head of the world, a person can be the master of all the ministers.
Without love, a person can only have courage,
Without moderation, a person can only have generosity,
And instead of staying behind, a person can go to the front.
This leads nowhere but to death.
The person who fights with love will win the battle,
The person who defends himself with love will be safe.
Heaven will save him and protect him with love.

is called the virtue of non-fighting.
This is called the ability to manage others.
This is called uniting with the law of Heaven.
Since ancient times, it has been the highest goal.

THE FUNCTION
OF THE
MYSTERIOUS

A military expert has said: I do not dare put myself forward as a host, but always act as a guest. I hesitate to advance an inch, but am willing to withdraw a foot.

This is advancing by not advancing, it is winning without arms, it is charging without hostility, it is seizing without weapons.

A great warrior has said, "I dare not be the host, I would rather be the guest; I dare not advance an inch, I would rather retire a foot."

Now this I call filling in without marshalling the ranks; baring the arms without preparing to fight; grasping the sword without unsheathing it;

The handbook of the strategist has said:

'Do not invite the fight, accept it instead,'

'Better a foot behind than an inch too far ahead,'

Which means:

Look a man straight in the face and make no move,

Roll up your sleeve and clench no fist,

Open your

A tactician in ancient times said:

"I do not dare to act as a host,

I prefer to act as a guest,

I do not dare to advance an inch,

I prefer to retreat a foot."

This implies that he does not muster his armies, as if he has no armies,

He does not roll up his sleeves, as if his arms are not ready,

There is a saying among military strategists:

'I dare not act as the host, but the guest.

I dare advance an inch, but retreat a foot.'

This is called conducting in non-conducting.

Pulling back without using force.

Facing the fight without engaging

There is no mistake greater than making light of an enemy. By making light of an enemy we lose our treasure.

Therefore when well-matched armies come to conflict, the one who is conscious of his weakness conquers.

and advancing upon the enemy without coming into conflict.

There is nothing so unfortunate as entering lightly into battle.

For in doing so we are in danger of losing that which is most precious.

Thus it happens that when opposing forces meet in battle, he who feels the pity of is assuredly conquers.

hand and show no weapon,

Bare your breast and find no foe.

But as long as there be a foe, value him,

Respect him, measure him, be humble toward him;

Let him not strip from you, however strong he be,

Compassion, the one wealth which can afford him.

He does not go out to battle, as if he has no weapons,

He does not fight, as if he has no enemies.

The greatest calamity is to underestimate the strength of the enemy,

For underestimating the strength of the enemy leads to the loss of our treasure of love.

Therefore, when armies clash on the battlefield,

The one that possesses the treasure will triumph.

the enemy.

Holding no weapons.

The greatest danger is to undervalue the enemy.

To undervalue the enemy will cause loss of the three treasures.

That is why when two forces fight against each other, the one that is full of sorrow will win.

THE DIFFICULTY
OF
UNDERSTANDING

My words are very easy to understand and very easy to put into practice, yet in all the world no one appears to understand them or to practice them.

Words have an ancestor (a preceding idea), deeds have a master (a

Easy are my words to know, and also to practice.

Yet none is able to understand nor yet to practice them.

For there is a remote origin for my words, and a supreme law for

My way is so simple to feel, so easy to apply,

That only a few will feel it or apply it.

If it were not the lasting way, the natural way to try,

If it were a passing

Words have an ancestor, deeds have a master.

It is easy to understand my words and practice them.

But all the people in the world do not know them,

And do not practice them.

Since they have knowledge, they do not know me.

When those that know

My words are very easy to understand, very easy to practise.

Yet no one in the world can understand them and put them into practice.

The words have a root.

The affairs have a sovereign.

Because

preceding purpose), and just as these are often not understood, so I am not understood.

They who understand me are very few, and on that account I am worthy of honor. The wise man wears wool (rather than silk) and keeps his gems out of sight.

my actions.

Not knowing these, men cannot know me.

Those who know me are few, and by them I am esteemed.

For the wise man is outwardly poor, but he carries his jewel in his bosom.

way, everyone would try it.

But however few shall go my way

Or feel concerned with me,

Some there are and those are they

Who witness what they see:

Sanity is a haircloth sheath

With a jewel underneath.

me are few, I am beyond all praise.

Therefore the sage wears coarse woolen clothes but carries jade jewels in his bosom,

He knows himself, but does not present himself,

He loves himself, but does not act arrogantly.

Therefore he rejects the latter and adopts the former.

people are ignorant, they do not understand me.

Those who understand me are few.

That is why I become valued.

This is why the sage does not flaunt himself but holds the treasure in his heart.

THE DISEASE OF
KNOWLEDGE

To recognize one's
ignorance of
unknowable things is
mental health, and to
be ignorant of
knowable things is
sickness.

To know one's
ignorance is the best
part of knowledge.

To be ignorant of
such knowledge is a
disease.

If one only regards it
as a disease,

A man who knows
how little he knows
is well,

A man who knows
how much he knows
is sick.

If, when you see the

Not knowing what
one knows is the
best,

To think that one
knows when one
does not know is
sick.

Only when one
becomes sick of

Knowing ignorance
is best.

Thinking one knows
is foolish.

Only by being a fool
can one

Only by grieving
over ignorance of
knowable things are
we in mental health.
The wise man is wise
because he
understands his
ignorance and is
grieved over it.

he will soon be cured
of it.

The wise man is
exempt from this
disease.

He knows it for what
it is, and so is free
from it.

symptoms, you can
tell,

Your cure is quick.

A sound man knows
that sickness makes
him sick

And before he
catches it his cure is
quick.

this sickness,

Is it possible to get
free of the sickness.

The sage is never
sick,

Since he is sick of
this sickness,

He is not sick.

avoid becoming a
fool.

The sage does not
think he knows,
therefore he is not a
fool.

TO CHERISH
ONE\\S SELF

When people are too ignorant to fear the fearsome thing, then it will surely come. Do not make the place where they dwell confining, the life they live wearisome.

When men do not have a right fear of present dangers, they run into extremes of peril.
Let them beware of enlarging the house, being wary of present conditions.
If they do not despise it,

Upon those who defy authority
It shall be visited,
But not behind prison walls
Nor through oppression of their kin;
Men sanely led
Are not led

If the people do not fear the ruling authority,
A much greater fear will befall them.
Be sure that you do not

When people lack a sense of awe, then disaster will descend upon them.
Do not narrow the living space of the mind.
Do not reject the inherent character.
Because one does not reject,

If they are let alone, they will not become restless. Therefore the wise man while not understanding himself regards himself, while cherishing he does not overvalue himself. Therefore he discards flattery and prefers regard.

no such weariness will arise.
This is why the Sage, while possessed of self-knowledge, does not parade himself.
He loves, but does not value himself highly.
Thus he can put away pride, and is content.

by duress.
To know yourself and not show yourself,
To think well of yourself and not tell of yourself,
Be that your no and your yes.

make them live in crowded quarters
Or make their lives unbearable.
Only when their living quarters are not crowded
Will their dissatisfaction disappear.

one will not be rejected.
That is why the sage knows himself but does not flaunt himself.
He loves himself but does not value himself.
Therefore he discards one and takes the other.

ACTION IS
DANGEROUS

Courage carried to daring leads to death. Courage restrained by caution leads to life. These two things, courage and caution, are sometimes beneficial and sometimes harmful. Some things are rejected by heaven, who can tell the reason?

He whose courage is expressed in daring will soon meet death.

He whose courage is shown in self-restraint will be preserved.

There are, then, two kinds of courage; the one is injurious and the other of advantage.

But who is to say why one of them should incur the judgement of Heaven?

That is why the Sage

A man with outward courage dares to die,

A man with inward courage dares to live;

But either of these men

Has a better and a worse side than the other.

And who can tell exactly to which qualities

The person who shows courage in daring will perish.

The person who shows courage in a lack of daring will live.

To know these two things means to differentiate between the one, which is beneficial, and the other, which is harmful.

Who knows that heaven loathes one of them?

The superior Tao

He who is brave and unscrupulous will meet his death.

He who is brave and cautious will stay alive.

Of these both, one leads to good, one leads to harm.

Everyone hates the bad - the reason why is clear.

That is why the

Therefore the wise man deems all acting difficult.

The Tao of heaven does not quarrel, yet it conquers. It speaks not, yet its response is good. It issues no summons but things come to it naturally because its devices are good. Heaven's net is vast, indeed! its meshes are wide but it loses nothing.

finds it difficult to act.

The celestial Tao does not strive, and yet overcomes everything.

It does not speak, yet is skilful in replying.

It does not call, yet things come to it readily.

It is quiet in its methods, yet its plans are thoroughly effective.

The net of Heaven has large meshes, and yet nothing escapes it!

heaven objects?

Heaven does nothing to win the day,

Says nothing-Is echoed,

Orders nothing-Is obeyed,

Advises nothing-Is right:

And which of us, seeing that nothing is outside the vast

Wide-meshed net of heaven, knows just how it is cast?

does not fight, yet it wins for certain.

It does not speak, yet it responds to everything.

It does not call, yet everyone comes to hear it.

It is not a tactician, yet it makes plans.

Heaven's net is all-embracing, and its holes are wide,

And even so, nothing escapes its sweep.

sage is always cautious.

The Tao of Heaven does not fight but wins,

does not speak but is answered,

is not summoned but appears,

does not plan but consults.

The net of Heaven is widely cast;

the mesh is loose, yet nothing slips through.

OVERCOMING
DELUSIONS

If the people do not fear death, how can one frighten them with death? If we teach people to fear death, then when one rebels he can be seized and executed; after that who will dare to rebel?

There is always an officer to execute a murderer, but if one takes the place of the executioner, it is like taking the place of a skilled carpenter at his hewing.

When the people do not fear death, of what use is it to overawe them with it as a penalty?

And if they were always held in fear of death, and I could lay my hand upon all evil doers and

People starve

If taxes eat their grain,

And the faults of starving people

Are the fault of their rulers.

That is why people rebel.

Men who have

When people do not fear death,

What is the use of frightening them with the death penalty?

When people are constantly afraid of death,

And we can arrest and execute criminals,

Who would dare to

If people are not afraid of death,

why threaten them with death to prevent them from committing a crime?

When people are afraid of death,

there are still those who are not afraid of it,

who will dare to commit a crime, and so why arrest

If one takes the place of the skilled carpenter he is liable to cut himself. (Therefore do not interfere with Tao.)

slay them, would I dare to do it?

There is always the Great Executioner!

For one to usurp that office is like a novice cutting out the work of a great architect.

Such a one rarely fails to cut his own hands!

to fight for their living

And are not afraid to die for it

Are higher men than those who, stationed high,

Are too fat to dare to die.

commit crimes?

Only the executioner kills.

To kill instead of the executioner is like a woodcutter taking a master-carpenter's place.

When someone carves instead of the master-carpenter,

He can usually expect to injure his hand.

and execute them?

There is an official executioner who is in charge of execution.

To kill on behalf of the executioner is like carving wood on behalf of the carpenter.

Those who cut wood on behalf of the carpenter can seldom escape from hurting their own hand.

LOSS BY
GREEDINESS

Starvation of a people comes when an official appropriates to himself too much of the taxes.

The people suffer from famine on account of the heavy taxation put upon them.

This is the cause of their need.

The people are difficult to govern because of the overbearing of their superiors.

This is the cause of

Death is no threat to people

Who are not afraid to die;

But even if these offenders feared death all day,

Who should be rash enough

To act as executioner?

The people are starving,

Because their clerks impose heavy taxes on them.

That is why they are starving.

It is difficult to govern the people,

Because their clerks interfere in their

The people are hungry.

It is because those who govern them consume too much in taxes.

That is why the people are hungry.

The people are hard to govern.

It is because those who govern them interfere too much.

That is

The reason a people are difficult to govern is because the officials are too meddlesome; the people make light of death because they are so absorbed in life's interests. The one who is not absorbed in life is more moral than he who esteems life.

their trouble.

The people make light of dying because of the great hardships of trying to live.

This is the reason for their indifference to death.

Therefore to keep living in obscurity is better than making overmuch of it.

Nature is executioner.

When man usurps the place,

A carpenter's apprentice takes the place of the master:

And 'an apprentice hacking with the master's axe

May slice his own hand.'

affairs.

That is why they are difficult to govern.

The people do not respect death,

Because their clerks direct them to seek life.

That is why they do not respect death.

why the people are hard to govern.

The people scorn death.

It is because they seek dearly for life.

That is why people treat death with disdain.

Only he who does not seek dearly for his life can value life worthily.

BEWARE OF
STRENGTH

When a man is living
he is tender and
fragile. When he dies
he is hard and stiff. It
is the same with
everything, the grass
and trees, in life, are
tender and delicate,
but when they die
they become rigid
and dry.

Therefore those who
are hard

Man at his birth is
supple and tender,
but in death he is
rigid and strong.

It is the same with
everything.

Trees and plants in
their early growth are
pliant and soft, but at
the end they are
withered and tough.

Thus rigidity and
strength are
concomitants of

Man, born tender and
yielding,

Stiffens and hardens
in death.

All living growth is
pliant,

Until death transfixes
it.

Thus men who have
hardened are 'kin of
death'

And men who

The living person is
soft and pliant, and is
hard and rigid in
death.

All creatures and
plants,

Are soft and
vulnerable in life,

And dry and brittle in
death.

Therefore it is said:

The hard and the
rigid are part of
death,

The soft and

A man is soft and
weak when living.

But hard and rigid
when dead.

The myriad creatures
and grass and plants,
when living, are soft
and fragile.

When dead, they are
dried and withered.

That is why the hard
and the rigid

and stiff belong to
death's domain, while
the tender and weak
belong to the realm
of life.

Therefore soldiers
are most invincible
when they will not
conquer. When a tree
is grown to its
greatest strength it is
doomed. The strong
and the great stay
below; the tender and
weak rise above.

death, but softness
and gentleness are
companions of life.

Therefore the warrior
who relies on his
strength cannot
conquer death, while
the powerful tree
becomes a mere
timber support.

For the place of the
strong and the firm is
below, while that of
the gentle and
yielding is above.

stay gentle are 'kin of
life.'

Thus a hard-hearted
army is doomed to
lose.

A tree hard-fleshed is
cut down:

Down goes the tough
and big,

Up comes the tender
sprig.

gentle are part of life.

This is the reason
why soldiers who are
too rigid

Do not triumph.

When the tree is too
rigid, it will break.

The stance of the
strong and the great
is stooped,

The stance of the
weak and the small is
erect.

are the disciples of
death, the soft and
the weak the
disciples of the
living.

Therefore an army
which is inflexible
cannot win.

A plant which is hard
will break.

The strong and hard
will fall.

The soft and weak
will overcome.

TAO OF HEAVEN

Tao of heaven resembles the stretching of a bow. The mighty it humbles, the lowly it exalts. They who have abundance it diminishes and gives to them who have need.

That is Tao of heaven; it depletes those who abound, and completes those who lack.

The human way is not so.

Like the bending of an archer's bow is the Tao of Heaven!

It brings down that which is high, and raises up that which is depressed.

It takes away where there is excess, and gives where there is deficiency.

The Tao of Heaven makes all things equal.

This Tao is not of man.

Man takes

Is not existence

Like a drawn bow?

The ends approach,

The height shortens, the narrowness widens.

True living would take from those with too much

Enough for those with too little,

Whereas man exacts from those with too little

Still more for those with

Is not the superior Tao like drawing a bow?

The high part moves downward, the low part moves upward,

What is full is reduced, what is insufficient is filled.

The superior Tao reduces the full, fills what is insufficient.

Man's Tao, in contrast, takes from the insufficient and gives to the full.

Who

Isn't the Tao of Heaven like stretching a bow?

When it is high, it presses down, when it is low, it lifts up.

When it is surplus, it reduces.

When it is deficient, it increases.

The Tao of Mankind is the opposite: it reduces the deficiency in order

Men take from those who lack to give to those who already abound. Where is the man who by his abundance can best serve the world?

The wise man makes but claims not, he accomplishes merit, yet is not attached to it, neither does he display his excellence. Is it not so?

from the needy to add to his own excess.

Who is he that, having a superabundance, can bring it to the service of the world?

Only he who has the Tao.

This is why the wise man acts without expectation of reward, and completes his task without claiming merit.

For thus he hides his wealth.

too much.

Now what man shall have wealth enough to share with all men

Save one who can freely draw from the common means?

A sane man needs no better support, no richer reward,

Than this common means,

Through which he is all men's equal.

can take from the full and give to the insufficient?

Only he who has the Tao can.

Therefore, the sage does not hoard anything for himself.

The more he helps others, the more he obtains for himself.

The superior Tao does good, and never does evil,

The sage's Tao acts, but never hurts others.

to add to the surplus.

Only the one who has the Tao offers his surplus to others.

Therefore the sage benefits others, yet claims no gratitude, accomplishes his task, yet assumes no merit.

It is only because he does not want to be considered as a virtuous person.

TRUST AND
FAITH

In the world nothing is more fragile than water, and yet of all the agencies that attack hard substances nothing can surpass it.

Of all things there is nothing that can take the place of Tao. By it the weak are conquerors of the strong, the pliable are conquerors of the rigid.

Nothing on earth is so weak and yielding as water, but for breaking down the firm and strong it has no equal.

This admits of no alternative.

All the world knows that the soft can wear away the hard, and the weak can conquer the strong,

What is more fluid, more yielding than water?

Yet back it comes again, wearing down the rigid strength

Which cannot yield to withstand it.

So it is that the strong are overcome by the weak,

The haughty

The weakest thing in the world can overcome the strongest thing in the world.

Nothing in the world can compare with the weakness of water, whose nature is limp and submissive,

But when it attacks the hardest and strongest of all, there is nothing more efficient,

Since there is no alternative to it.

The weak can overcome the strong, and the soft can conquer the

There is nothing under Heaven softer and weaker than water,

yet to attack the hard and the strong nothing can surpass it, nothing can take its place.

That is why the soft overcomes the hard, the weak surpasses the strong.

Everyone knows this, yet no one is able to practise it.

In the world every one knows this, but none practice it.

Therefore the wise man declares: he who is guilty of the country's sin may be the priest at the altar. He who is to blame for the country's misfortunes, is often the Empire's Sovereign. True words are often paradoxical.

but none can carry it out in practice.

Therefore the Sage says: He who bears the reproach of his country is really the lord of the land. He who bears the woes of the people is in truth their king.

The words of truth are always paradoxical.

by the humble.

This we know

But never learn,

So that when wise men tell us,

'He who bites the dust

Is owner of the earth,

He who is scapegoat

Is king,'

They seem to twist the truth.

tough:

The whole world knows that, but does not abide by it.

Therefore the sage says:

The person who bears all the disgrace of the country can be the master of the land,

The person who bears all the troubles of the country can be the king of the world.

These are words of truth,

Even though they sound like nothing more than a paradox.

Therefore the sage says:

He who can take upon himself the humiliation and insults inflicted on the country is called the king of a state.

He who can take upon himself the bad luck suffered by the country is called the emperor of the land under Heaven.

Straightforward words often seem contrary.

ENFORCING CONTRACTS

When reconciling
great hatred there
will some remain.
How can it be made
good?

Therefore the wise
man accepts the debit
side of the account
and does not have to
enforce payment
from others.

When a compromise
is effected after a
long dispute, one of
the parties retains a
grudge: how can this
be called a good
settlement?

Therefore the wise
man takes his part of
the bond, and does
not insist

If terms to end a
quarrel leave bad
feeling,

What good are they?

So a sensible man
takes the poor end of
the

Give love in return
for fierce hatred.

Otherwise, when the
fierce hatred is
forgotten,

A little of it will still
remain.

And how can this end
well?

Therefore the sage
keeps the left half of
a contract,

And does

When peace is made
between two great
rivals,

some resentment will
surely remain.

How can this be
considered a good
deed?

That is why the sage
keeps his half of the
agreement,

but does not require
the debt from the
other party.

That is

They who have
virtue (teh) keep their
obligations, they who
have no virtue insist
on their rights. Tao
of heaven has no
favorites but always
helps the good man.

upon having the
other.

The virtuous man
attends only to his
engagements in the
bond, while the man
without virtue
contrives for his own
advantage.

The Tao of Heaven
has no favourites; it
always aids the good
man.

bargain

Without quibbling.

It is sensible to make
terms,

Foolish to be a
stickler:

Though heaven
prefer no man,

A sensible man
prefers heaven.

not check what the
other holder has to
do.

The virtuous person
acts according to the
contract,

The person who is
not virtuous resorts
to lawsuits and
disputations.

"The superior Tao is
not biased,

It always
accompanies the
virtuous person."

how a man with
virtue takes charge of
the agreement.

But a man without
virtue requires the
other to fulfil his
obligation,

like a wheel running
in a rut.

The Tao of Heaven
shows no
favouritism: it is
always on the side of
good men.

CONTENTMENT

In a small country with few people let there be officers over tens and hundreds but not to exercise power. Let the people be not afraid of death, nor desire to move to a distance. Then though there be ships and carriages, they will have no occasion to use them. Though there be armor and weapons there will be no occasion for donning them.

If I had a small kingdom and but ten or a hundred men of ability, I would not administrate with them.

I would teach the people to look upon death as a grievous thing, and then they would not go abroad to meet it.

Though they had boats and carriages, yet they would not go away in them.

Though they had armour, yet they would never have occasion to wear it.

The people would return

If a land is small and its people are few,

With tenfold enough to have and to do,

And if no one has schooled them to waste supply

In the country for which they live and would die,

Then not a boat, not a cart

Tempts this people to depart,

Not a dagger, not a bow

Has to be drawn or bent for show,

People reckon

Imagine a small land with few people.

Even if it contains plenty of vessels, I will not use them.

I will induce the people to respect death, and not to go wandering far afield.

Even if they have boats and chariots, they will not travel in them,

Even if they have weapons and armor, they will not bear them.

I will bring them back to

A small country with a limited population ensures that even though the people may have many valuables, they do not need to use them.

The ruler lets the people consider death as a serious matter,

so that they will not wish to leave their homes.

Though they have ships and carriages, they will not use them;

and though they have soldiers and arms, there is no need to deploy them.

The ruler lets the

The people can return to p. 52 knotted cords for their records, they can delight in their food, be proud of their clothes, be content with their dwellings, rejoice in their customs.

Other states may be close neighbors, their cocks and dogs may be mutually heard, people will come to old age and die but will have no desire to go or come.

to the use of the quipu.

They should find their coarse food sweet, think their plain clothes grand, regard their homes as places of rest, and take delight in their own simple pleasures.

Though the neighbouring state could be seen by us, and the crowing of the cocks and the barking of the dogs could be heard,

Yet my people would grow old, and die before ever feeling the need of having intercourse with it.

by knots in a cord,

Relish plain food on the board,

Simple clothing suits them well,

And they remain content to dwell

In homes their customs can afford.

Though so close to their own town another town grow

They can hear its dogs bark and its roosters crow,

Yet glad of life in the village they know,

Where else in the world shall they need to go?

knotted cords instead of writings.

Their food will satisfy them,

Their clothing will please them,

Their dwellings will be full of tranquillity,

Their customs will be full of happiness.

Even though the neighboring lands are within view,

And the crowing of the roosters and the barking of the dogs from there are audible,

The people of that small country will not go there in their lifetime.

people return to the time of knotting ropes to record information.

They will find pleasure in their tasteless food.

They will find beauty in their simple clothes.

They will find peace in their small houses.

They will enjoy their own customs.

They can see the neighbouring country.

They can even hear the sounds of each other's roosters and dogs.

They will grow old and die, but remain content never to go to the neighbouring country.

THE NATURE OF
THE ESSENTIAL

Faithful words are often not pleasant; pleasant words are often not faithful. Good men do not dispute; the ones who dispute are not good. The learned men are often not the wise men, nor the wise men, the learned.

Sincere words are not grand.

Grand words are not faithful.

The man of Tao does not dispute.

Those who know it are not learned.

The learned do not know it.

The wise man does not lay up treasure.

The more he expends on others, the

Real words are not vain,

Vain words not real;

And since those who argue prove nothing

A sensible man does not argue.

A sensible man is wiser than he knows,

While a fool knows more than is wise.

Therefore a sensible man does not devise resources:

The greater his use to others

The greater their use to him,

The more he yields to others

The more they yield to him.

The way of life cleaves without cutting:

Which, without need to say,

Should be man's way.

LAOTZU

"The way to do is to be."

He who knows does not speak,

He who speaks does not know.

He who speaks the truth is not arrogant,

He who is arrogant does not speak the truth.

He who has good qualities does

Truthful words are not beautiful.

Beautiful words are not truthful.

Good men do not argue.

He who argues is not good.

He who knows, does not learn everything.

He who learns everything, does not know.

The sage does not hoard.

The wise man does not hoard, but ever working for others, he will the more exceedingly acquire. Having given to others freely, he himself will have in plenty. Tao of heaven benefits but does not injure. The wise man's Tao leads him to act but not to quarrel.

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more he gains for himself.

The more he gives to others, the more he has for his own.

This is the Tao of Heaven, which penetrates but does not injure.

This is the Tao of the wise man, who acts but does not strive.

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not argue,

He who argues does not have good qualities.

He who has learned a lot does not know,

He who knows has not learned a lot.

Therefore the sage does not display his qualities.

The more he does for others, the more he has.

The more he gives to others, the greater his abundance.

The Tao of Heaven gives benefit but no harm.

The Tao of the sage accomplishes good deeds but makes no claims.